

INBRIEF



‘Click & Commit’ campaign launched on World TB Day

A community campaign, ‘Click & Commit - A Public Pledge to End TB’, was launched on World TB Day by Resource Group for Education and Advocacy for Community Health (REACH), a Chennai-based non-profit. Director of REACH Ramya Ananthakrishnan; Shivakumar, affected community representative; representatives from Sundaram Fasteners Limited; Annammal, family caregiver; Nalini Krishnan, Executive Secretary, REACH; S. Sivamurugan, Executive Committee Member, REACH; Amarnath Reddy of AMARA Homes; Surekha Reddy of DODLA Dairy; Nirmala Lakshman, Chairperson, The Hindu Group, and Swetha, India Motor Parts & Accessories Ltd, participated.

Man held for cheating tenant by leasing out mortgaged flat

The police arrested Rajagopalan, 59, for allegedly cheating Deepak, 29, of Cuddalore of ₹20 lakh by leasing out a flat that was under mortgage and was auctioned off for non-repayment of loan. According to the police, the crime came to light when the complainant received an eviction notice from a firm that had purchased the property in the auction.

Text & Context and Science

Weekday features on *The Hindu* epaper (epaper.thehindu.com) carry explainers, special articles and quizzes. In the latest issue (March 25, Wednesday), the following articles are available:

■ When the Chief Justice steps away
newsth.live/chiefjustice

■ How BioPharma SHAKTI can transform biologics with non-animal models
newsth.live/bioshakti

You can use your smartphone's inbuilt features to access these articles. If it's an Android phone, use Google Lens to read and tap the url to access an article. If it's an iPhone, use Live Text on camera to do the same.

☀️ Timings CHENNAI		
WEDNESDAY, MAR. 25		
☀️ RISE	06:10	☀️ SET 18:20
🌙 RISE	11:18	🌙 SET 00:00
THURSDAY, MAR. 26		
☀️ RISE	06:10	☀️ SET 18:20
🌙 RISE	12:21	🌙 SET 00:47
FRIDAY, MAR. 27		
☀️ RISE	06:09	☀️ SET 18:20
🌙 RISE	13:23	🌙 SET 01:45

Chennai Weather	max	min
Tiruvallur	34	22
Chennai Airport	34	25
Chennai City	32	25

Chennai Airport Today
34°C Morning will be pleasant. Day will be warm. Night also will be pleasant. Mostly dry weather to prevail.

Chennai Airport Tomorrow
35°C The weather will be dry. Day will be warm. Night will be pleasant.

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THE HINDU
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A coastal area where affordable housing and livelihood security are major issues

Residents want the government to implement social welfare measures for the economically disadvantaged. Other demands include redevelopment of dilapidated TNUHDB houses, establishment of a maternity hospital, and flood mitigation measures, particularly in areas along the coastline

CONSTITUENCY WATCH

Aloysius Xavier Lopez
CHENNAI

While Chennai District Election Officials were covering up inscriptions at Robinson Park in Royapuram, the location where the DMK was launched in 1949, local resident A. Putli, 50, was busy selling buttermilk and aloe vera to earn her livelihood.

“Livelihood security is a major issue here,” she said. Ever since she learned that her father had named her after Mahatma Gandhi’s mother, she has been consistent in her commitment to a certain political ideology. But social welfare measures by the government are what matters the most for poor residents such as her in Royapuram Assembly constituency, where a significant number of voters belong to the socially weaker sections of society.

“I have received ₹1,000 under the *Kalaigir Magalir Urimai Thittam*. I am a beneficiary of the free bus scheme, *Vidyal Payanam*. But I intend to vote for the candidate who will also resolve the housing problem in our area. A significant number of the electors in this constituency have to work hard every day for their livelihood. Our decision to vote will depend on welfare schemes that protect our dignity,” Ms. Putli said.

Royapuram

A significant number of electors in this constituency belong to the socially weaker sections of society

WARDS 48, 49, 50, 51, 52, 53

KEY ISSUES

■ Livelihood issues of various sections, including fishermen and daily wage labourers

■ Flooding of residential areas

■ Problems in sewerage network

■ Delay in the issuance of free house site *patta* to local residents

■ Poor condition of high-rise buildings where economically weaker sections live

■ Poor maintenance of neighbourhoods managed by the Tamil Nadu Urban Habitat Development Board

Many residents like her in the constituency have demanded affordable housing for the poor, while some want free house site *pattas*. Many electors have also requested the government to redevelop the dilapidated houses of the Tamil Nadu Urban Habitat Development Board (TNUHDB), particularly along the coast, where corrosion is a major problem in reinforced cement concrete structures.

K. Sulakshana, a senior citizen residing along the



Idream R. Murthy of the DMK defeated D. Jayakumar of the AIADMK by a margin of 27,779 votes in 2021



Infrastructure boost: MC Road in Old Washermenpet, where development work is under way. M. SRINATH

Electors before SIR:

Total: 1,98,576

Men : 96,888

Women : 1,01,611

Others : 77

Electors after SIR:

Total: 1,56,931

Men : 75,870

Women : 81,004

Others : 57

Number of polling stations

194

creased after the Metro Rail was constructed near Maharani Theatre. “The Port Trust increased the height of the ground. This has caused flooding in the vicinity. We have demanded work on improving the pumping infrastructure. The flood level was 3 ft. in 2023. Last year, there was no flooding. But the risk remains,” he said.

‘Improve coordination’ G. Shankar, another resident, said some of the residents who need *patta* had to get clearance from the Port Trust. MLAs have to improve coordination with various government agencies, including the Port Trust, Railways, and local bodies, to resolve civic issues, residents said.

D. Jayakumar, former AIADMK Minister who had won from Royapuram in 1991, 2001, 2006, 2011, and 2016, said he had played a key role in constructing multi-storied houses and replacing all the huts in the constituency during his tenure. “The DMK government failed to maintain the structures. Electors have understood how much we worked for the constituency only after electing a new MLA in 2021,” he said.

Pointing to the AIADMK’s role in preventing pollution caused by iron ore and coal handling in the port, Mr. Jayakumar said the constituency had remained green as residents had planted 50,000 trees with government support during his tenure.

Congress councillor Suresh Kumar said work on pumping stations had been completed to resolve civic issues and old drains had been restored for flood mitigation. “Electors have demanded measures to protect the livelihood of those who depend on fishing.”

S. Ramesh Kumar, 53, a resident, said major Dravidian party candidates who intend to contest from the constituency were hopeful but people were looking for some new candidate, who would be innovative in their approach for resolving civic issues. “Electors were angry when elected representatives tried to play down the demand for dignified housing for the poor. Party representatives who mocked the residents without *patta* may not get support during the election campaign,” he said. Pointing to the launch of youth leagues of new parties such as the TVK in many streets of Royapuram constituency, residents said this was expected to split votes for the two Dravidian majors.

DMK functionary N. Manogaran, who is the president of the Arignar Anna Poonga Walkers’ Association at Robinson Park, said many of the 3,500 walkers, who visit the park, were discussing the need to provide affordable housing for all eligible residents in the constituency, welfare measures for poor residents, improvement of parks and playgrounds, and development of parking spaces.

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Only structured party machinery combined with popularity can ensure success: Ezhilan

In an interview with *The Hindu*, doctor-legislator N. Ezhilan of the DMK speaks on his tenure as first-time MLA from Thousand Lights Assembly constituency, Vijay's political entry shaping the 2026 elections, flood mitigation, revamping health infrastructure, access to public spaces and more

INTERVIEW

N. Ezhilan

N. Sai Charan
CHENNAI

Any popular personality entering politics will attract limelight. But only a structured party machinery combined with popularity can ensure success, observes Thousand Lights DMK MLA N. Ezhilan. During a freewheeling conversation with *The Hindu*, Dr. Ezhilan spoke about his constituency in Chennai, key developmental issues in the city and broader political questions. Here are the excerpts.

Thousand Lights is a highly urbanised constituency. Tamil Nadu Chief Minister M.K. Stalin had contested several times from here. Having completed five years as an MLA, how do you assess your tenure?

Thousand Lights is a historical constituency. Arignar Anna [C.N. Annadurai] lived here. The first mid-day meal scheme by Sir Pitti Theagarayar began at a school here. Justice Party leader A.T. Pannierselvam and Muthamizh Arignar Kalaigarnar [M. Karunanidhi] lived in this Assembly

segment. In 2021, the Chief Minister gave me his constituency to provide an opportunity for professionals and social activists. In the first few months, I conducted inspections across departments such as Electricity, Metro Water and Sewage, Greater Chennai Corporation (GCC), and the Habitat Board [TNUHDB].

Thousand Lights is also a low-lying area. When I presented flood mitigation issues before the Thirupugazh Committee, it was pointed out that stormwater drains and sewage lines were being used interchangeably, leading to overflow during rain. To address this, we created 30 km of stormwater drains and cleared the Mambalam and Puliur canals. Embankments were strengthened and sewage inlets plugged to ensure free flow of water. We took up sewer line expansion. During the 2015 Chennai floods, 42 locations faced waterlogging. This was reduced to 16, and now limited to just two places.

Thousand Lights has several important educational institutions and hospitals. With new public health infrastructure added in the past five years, how important is it to build such a holistic model?

I focused on developing



N. Ezhilan said during his tenure, he focused on developing health, education, infrastructure, and sports for youngsters. S. SHIVARAJ

four ecosystems: health, education, infrastructure, and sports for youngsters. Our Primary Health Centres (PHCs) had excellent facilities, but people preferred going to government medical colleges even for basic needs. So, I revamped the PHCs. One centre is now dedicated to master health check-ups with full diagnostic facilities. Pregnant women from across the GCC go there.

We have also set up a TB centre for microscopic analysis and introduced model PHCs and evening clinics.

I addressed the shortage of doctors by taking it up with the government and the Chief Minister. Being a doctor helped me build this health ecosystem.

My role in the State Planning Commission also gave me the opportunity to coordinate across departments.

Residents in Thousand Lights flag three key issues: parking constraints, persistent sewer problems, and access to public spaces...

Parking is largely a Chennai-wide problem. Here, I formed a working group with Chennai Unified Metropolitan Transport Authority (CUMTA) to address last-mile connectivity. In Phase-II, we are planning to identify unutilised GCC spaces and organise parking bases with security, cameras and monitoring systems. On sewer issues, during the last five years, revamping has been completed in 110 streets. Another 100 streets will be taken up in the next phase. Sewage is now pumped to a central facility having biofilters and treated near the Nungambakkam burial ground before being dis-

charged into the Cooum.

Across Chennai, pedestrians continue to face poor walkways and encroachments, that discourage walking. At the same time, how can pedestrian plazas like those in Pondy Bazaar or Khader Nawaz Khan Road be designed without causing spillover issues such as parking pressure in nearby residential areas?

Take Avvai Shanmugam Salai where several schools are located. In the mornings, there used to be a lot of commotion with school vans being parked everywhere on the road. I asked that the children be dropped near school and made to walk. We also widened the pedestrian walkway. But, vans began parking on the walkway itself. The police carried out evacuation drives and we regulated it. Now, a habit change is slowly taking shape. On pedestrian plazas, bunk shops started coming up after we created the spaces. So, I worked with the Corporation to introduce a proper licensing mechanism and marked out vending spaces. When the Street Vendors Act is implemented properly, it would ensure that their livelihoods are not affected as well. Also, for marked spaces, we must be persis-

tent with evacuation drives. In places such as Khader Nawaz Khan Road, we held public consultations. Some residents have concerns, and options including FSI exemptions are being explored. It is a delicate balance that we are trying to establish.

How do you see the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam's (TVK) entry in shaping the 2026 elections?

It is better to assess this with a yardstick. Have they contested local body polls, a byelection or even the recent Parliamentary election? At present, it is largely perception-based. Around 13% to 14% of voters in Tamil Nadu have consistently supported alternatives to the two Dravidian parties. That is not new. Any popular personality entering politics will attract limelight. But only a structured party combined with popularity can reach success. According to a survey, about 8% to 10% of votes come to a party in Tamil Nadu based on leadership appeal, beyond party vote banks. Vijay is popular, but he does not have a party structure yet. When Vijayakant launched the DMDK, he had already built organisational experience through his work for the South Indian Film Artistes Association. That structure was visible.

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Experts stress need for early detection of colorectal cancer

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Only 11.7% of residents in Chennai recognise blood in stool as a warning sign of colorectal cancer, according to a nationwide Lifestyle and Digestive Health Awareness Survey. The survey, supported by Merck Specialties Private Limited, covered 10,198 respondents aged between 25 and 65 across 14 major Indian cities. The findings were released as part of Colorectal Cancer Awareness Month in March.

City-specific data from Chennai, based on responses from 203 participants, revealed that 83.2% delay visiting a doctor when bowel habits change. More than half – 57.1% – reported experiencing irregular bowel movements, while 89.3% said they rely on self-medication or

home remedies instead of seeking medical advice.

Experts said these trends could lead to delayed diagnosis of colorectal cancer, which is largely treatable when detected early.

S. Subramanian, founder-chairman and managing director, VS Hospitals, Anita Ramesh, senior consultant medical oncologist, Kauvery Hospital, S. Rajasundaram, senior surgical oncologist, Iswarya Hospital, and S. Viswanath of Dr. Rela Institute and Medical Centre were present at the event held for the report's release.

The survey found that over 80% of respondents across cities were unaware that blood in stool can be an early sign of colorectal cancer, underscoring the need for greater public awareness and early screening.

Customs seize narcotic substances at airport

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Officers of the Air Intelligence Unit (AIU) of Chennai Customs seized about 5 kg of narcotic substances

from an international passenger at the Chennai airport and arrested him.

Upon examination of the passenger's check-in baggage, officers found 10 airtight transparent po-

lythene packets. The packets were found to contain 4.93 kg of green flowering and fruiting tops suspected to be ganja.

Later, he admitted that he had agreed to transport

the contraband in return for money.

He was subsequently arrested under relevant provisions of the Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances (NDPS) Act.

Lawyer held for sexual assault on girl

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The All-Women Police on Tuesday arrested Bharath, 28, an advocate, on charges of committing aggravated penetrative sexual assault on a 12-year-old girl.

The police action followed a complaint from the child's father stating that the Class VII student was sexually assaulted while alone at home. The police said the girl was learning dance at a private charitable trust.

The child disclosed what happened to her to an administrator at the dance school. While the girl was alone at home on Monday, Bharath barged into the house and repeatedly committed the offence.

Complaint filed

The administrator informed the girl's parents, which led to the police complaint. Investigation found that Bharath had been sexually assaulting the girl for five years.

The police registered a case under sections of the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act and arrested Bharath, who is an area organiser for the DMK advocates' wing. He was remanded in judicial custody.



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Alandur lacks basic amenities such as piped drinking water supply and underground drainage in some areas; sources in the DMK contend that the government has improved civic infrastructure

HC dismisses S.P. Velumani’s plea against I-T assessment order on 2016 poll expenses

The assessment order was passed in 2022 by treating ₹7 crore allegedly given by the former Minister to SRS Mining for distribution in various constituencies as unexplained expenditure

Mohamed Imranullah S.
CHENNAI

The Madras High Court on Tuesday dismissed a writ petition filed by former AIADMK Minister S.P. Velumani in 2023 challenging an assessment order passed against him by the Income Tax (I-T) department in 2022, after finding that he had given ₹7 crore in cash to SRS Mining for distribution to various constituencies during the 2016 Legislative Assembly elections held in the State.

Justice C. Saravanan dismissed the plea, with liberty to prefer a statutory appeal, after I-T department senior standing counsel A.P. Srinivas contended that the assessee ought not to have filed the writ petition challenging the order



S.P. Velumani contended that his income for the year 2017-18 was only ₹4.92 lakh.

passed for the assessment year 2017-18 without availing the statutory remedy of approaching the first appellate authority under the Income Tax Act of 1961.

Explaining the background of the case, the standing counsel told the court that Mr. Velumani, during his stint as Minister

for Local Administration in the AIADMK government, had filed I-T returns on January 23, 2018 disclosing a total taxable income of just ₹4.92 lakh which included his salary of ₹4.44 lakh and ₹48,000 being income from other sources.

However, a search and seizure operation conducted by the I-T sleuths in the premises related to businessman J. Sekar Reddy’s SRS Mining on December 8, 2016 revealed that Mr. Velumani had given ₹7 crore in cash to the private company for being distributed in constituencies in which AIADMK and its alliance partners had contested elections that year.

Responding to a notice issued by the I-T department seeking explanation as to why the ₹7 crore should not be added to his

income for the purpose of recovering tax along with penalty, Mr. Velumani had feigned ignorance about any such money having been given by him to the private company and asserted that his income for the year 2017-18 was only ₹4.92 lakh as it had been declared in his I-T returns.

However, after taking into consideration the seized materials and the corroborative evidence, the assessing officer had treated the ₹7 crore as unexplained expenditure and determined the total taxable income of Mr. Velumani as ₹7.04 crore for the assessment year 2017-18.

He also decided to initiate penalty proceedings and hence, the former Minister had rushed to the court with the present writ petition in 2023.

Trimbak Municipal Council, Trimbakeshwar

Outward No.6024/2026Date-24/03/2026

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Chief Officer, Trimbak Municipal Council, Trimbak, Tal.-Trimbakeshwar, Dist. - Nashik, State - Maharashtra invites bids in online form for Eleven (11) works of Development Works in Eleven Akhadas in Trimbak Municipal Council, under the Simhashtha Kumbhmela works. The tender documents will be available on the website **www.mahatenders.gov.in** from 25/03/2026 to 02/04/2026 up to 05.00 PM. The last date for submission of tenders is **02/04/2026**.

Note: All necessary details, subsequent notices, and clarifications will be published online on the **www.mahatenders.gov.in** website.

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Rahul Patil,
Chief Officer,
Trimbak Municipal Council

Sd/-
Triveni Tungar,
President,
Trimbak Municipal Council

Municipal Corporation Chhatrapati Sambhajanagar
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Fax No.(0240) 2331213

No./CSMC/BOT/103/2026Date 24/3/2026

CORRIGENDUM

Reference:- No./BOT/CSMC/2026/90, dated: 02/03/2026

Tender notice for Development of Commercial Complex (Shops & Offices), Banquet / Exhibition Hall on Build Operate and Transfer Basis situated at CTS No.3208, Nehru Bhavan, Buddilane, Chhatrapati Sambhajanagar Municipal Corporation, Chhatrapati Sambhajanagar. Tender ID: 2026-AMCA-1283163-1 Published in daily newspapers and also on **www.mahatenders.gov.in**. As per the above reference Schedule of bid opening process of last date of submission 25/03/2026 is changed and extended to 05/04/2026 up to 16.00 hrs is considered. Schedule of Opening of Technical Bid and for further Details will be published on **www.mahatenders.gov.in** portal. Rest of the conditions remains unchanged.

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Tamil Nadu

From Page One

AIADMK assures ration cardholders of free dal, cooking oil in manifesto

Among the other assurances given by the AIADMK were the revival of nearly 2,000 Amma Clinics; conversion of all city buses into electric vehicles; and a subsidy of ₹30,000 for 1 kilowatt (KW) and ₹60,000 for 2 KW of rooftop solar panels installed at houses.

The party said it would urge the Union government to allow night flights and establish cargo transport facilities at the Thoothukudi airport, apart from restoring the 50% concession in rail fare for senior citizens and journalists.

On the sensitive issue of the re-introduction of the Old Pension Scheme for State government employees, the AIADMK said the Contributory Pension Scheme and the Tamil Nadu Assured Pension Scheme would be reviewed. The income ceiling for journalists' pension would be scrapped, it said.

An appeal would be made to the Union government to provide "dual citizenship" to Sri Lankan refugees living in rehabilitation camps, it added.

As for the Goods and Services Tax (GST), the party said it would urge the Centre to include pump sets in the list of agricultural machinery equipment for reducing the tax rate from 18% to 5%. An identical downward revision would be recommended for recycled plastic waste and products manufactured from it, and for the raw materials required for making eco-friendly paper bags, it said.

The party expressed its commitment to "transform the State quickly" into a one trillion dollar economy.

When asked why he chose Mylapore to launch his election campaign, Mr. Palaniswami said "proximity" was the reason. Had he been in Salem, he would have done it from there, he added.

To a question on concluding the talks with other allies, the AIADMK leader said the negotiations were under way, and would be completed in a few days.

He said the alliance between the PMK faction led by party founder S. Ramadoss and the All India Puratchi Thalaivar Makkal Munnetra Kazhagam led by V.K. Sasikala would have no impact on the NDA's prospects.

DMK finalises poll pact with allies, set to contest 175 seats

The ruling party allots eight seats to its long-time partner VCK and 10 seats to its new ally DMDK. MNM founder Kamal Haasan opts out of the fray, but extends full support to the DMK alliance

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The ruling DMK on Tuesday finalised the seat-sharing arrangements for the Assembly election by allocating 10 seats to its new ally DMDK (in addition to a Rajya Sabha seat granted earlier) and eight seats to its long-time partner VCK.

MNM founder Kamal Haasan opted out of the fray, but extended full support to the DMK-led Secular Progressive Alliance (SPA).

The ruling party is likely to contest 175 of the 234 constituencies in the State, along with candidates of other parties that have agreed to contest on the DMK's 'Rising Sun' symbol.

On Tuesday morning, VCK leader Thol. Thirumavalavan met DMK president and Chief Minister M.K. Stalin and signed the agreement. In the evening, DMDK leader Premallatha Vijayakant and Mr. Stalin signed the pact at Anna Arivalayam.

So far, the DMK has allocated 66 seats to its allies – 28 to the Congress, 10 to the DMDK, eight to the VCK, five each to the CPI and the CPI(M), four to the MDMK, and two each to the Indian Union Muslim League, the Kongunadu



DMK leader Premallatha Vijayakant and DMK president and Chief Minister M.K. Stalin at the signing of the agreement on Tuesday.

Makkal Desiya Katchi (KMDK), and the Manitha-neya Makkal Katchi (MMK). Both the KMDK and the MMK will contest the election on the DMK's symbol, while the DMDK will do so in three of the four seats it has been allotted.

The DMK had already allocated a Rajya Sabha seat to the DMDK. Subsequently, DMDK treasurer L.K. Sudhish was elected to the Rajya Sabha.

The VCK will contest the election in six reserved Assembly constituencies and two general constituencies. In the 2021 election, the VCK contested from Kattumannarkoil (SC), Cheyyur (SC), Nagapattinam, Thiruporur, Arakkonam (SC), and Vanur (SC). It won four seats, and lost in Arakkonam and Vanur.

Addressing the media,

Mr. Thirumavalavan said he had discussed with Mr. Stalin the resolution passed by his party on Monday (March 23), seeking seats in "two digits" for the Assembly election and a Rajya Sabha seat in 2028. He said 23 parties were part of the SPA, which he described as an ideological alliance meant to counter "right-wing religious forces". At this juncture, the VCK had decided to settle for eight seats, given that the victory of the alliance was as important as the interests of his party, he said.

Mr. Thirumavalavan said the VCK bore greater responsibility for defeating the "right-wing alliance of the Sangh Parivar" as well as forces that distort the ideologies of Karl Marx, B.R. Ambedkar, and Periyar E.V. Ramasamy on the

pretext of opposing Dravidian politics. He said his party did not broach the subject of a Rajya Sabha seat at this time, as all vacancies had been filled. The VCK would approach the DMK whenever a vacancy arises in the future, he said.

Speaking to reporters, Ms. Premallatha expressed confidence that the DMK-led alliance would win in over 200 constituencies, and that Mr. Stalin would become Chief Minister again. A five-member committee would be formed on behalf of the DMDK to hold talks with the DMK to decide the list of constituencies, she said, adding that the DMDK candidates' list would be released on March 27.

Later in the day, Mr. Haasan met Mr. Stalin at the DMK headquarters. Announcing his party's decision, Mr. Haasan said the formation of 'Dravidian Model 2.0' was a necessity. "I will soon participate in the swearing-in ceremony of Chief Minister M.K. Stalin to congratulate him," he added. In a post on X, Mr. Stalin, while referring to Mr. Haasan's statement that not entering the electoral fray was not a sacrifice but a duty, said that what Mr. Haasan had done was, indeed, a sacrifice.

Cash, goods worth ₹178.78 crore seized as of March 24: ECI

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI



Archana Patnaik

The Election Commission of India (ECI) on Tuesday said it had seized cash and goods worth ₹178.78 crore as of March 24, as part of expenditure monitoring and enforcement activities for the Assembly election in Tamil Nadu.

In a statement, Chief Electoral Officer Archana Patnaik said ₹34.64 crore in cash, liquor worth ₹0.79 crore, drugs and narcotic substances worth ₹6.76 crore, precious metals worth ₹112.37 crore, and freebies worth ₹24.22 crore had been seized.

To ensure strict adherence to the Model Code of Conduct, and to prevent electoral violations, a multi-tier enforcement mechanism was being followed across the State, she said. A total of 2,169 flying squad teams had been deployed, and they were functioning round-the-clock and promptly responding to complaints received through the cVigil app and other channels, she added.

Curbs on exit polls
Conducting and publishing exit polls through print or electronic media is prohibited between 7 a.m. on April 9 (the beginning of the Assembly elections in four States and a Union

Territory) and 6.30 p.m. on April 29 (the end of the elections), the ECI said on Tuesday.

The order has been issued under the Representation of the People Act, 1951.

In a statement, the Chief Electoral Officer said polling for the Tamil Nadu Assembly election would be held between 7 a.m. and 6 p.m. on April 23.

Under the provisions of the Act, the display of any election matter, including the results of opinion polls or surveys, in any electronic media would be prohibited during the 48 hours till the conclusion of polling in the State, she added.

INBRIEF



TMC(M) gets 5 seats in NDA, to contest on BJP's 'Lotus' symbol

The Tamil Maanila Congress (Moopanar), led by G.K. Vasan, has been allocated five seats as part of the AIADMK-led National Democratic Alliance for the Assembly election. The party will contest on the BJP's 'Lotus' symbol in Oddanchathiram, Erode West, Ranipet, Killiyoor, and Kumbakonam. Speaking to *The Hindu*, Mr. Vasan confirmed that his party had been allocated five seats. Since his party's symbol was under dispute, it had decided to contest the poll under the BJP's symbol, he said. Meanwhile, the Tamilaga Makkal Munnetra Kazhagam, led by John Pandian, has also been allocated a seat. It is set to contest the Rajapalayam seat.

Rajesh B. Nair
PUDUCHERRY

The cohesiveness of the INDIA bloc has been put to the test after the decision of the Congress, the DMK, the CPI, and the VCK to field candidates against each other in several of the 30 Assembly constituencies in the Union Territory.

On the last day of filing of nominations on Monday, since there was uncertainty over the number of seats and constituencies distributed among the allies, candidates of all four parties filed their nominations for their preferred seats.

The parties asked their respective candidates to submit the nominations, hoping they could prevail upon the applicants to withdraw their nominations before the deadline of March 26 (Thursday)



Congress and DMK leaders met after the deadline for filing nominations ended on Monday.

prescribed by the Election Commission of India, once the leaders of the alliance partners come to a mutual understanding.

After the nominations were filed on Monday, leaders of the DMK and the Congress met in the evening to finalise the number of seats and constituencies the parties would contest. A day after the discussions, the DMK on Tuesday re-

leased a list of 13 candidates with the names of constituencies given to each nominee. The party also allocated a seat to the VCK from its quota of 14.

However, the Congress was yet to release the list of candidates and constituencies after the discussions with the DMK.

Among the 13 constituencies that found a place on the DMK's list, the Con-

gress had given Form A and B (party authorisation forms) to candidates in Kalapet, Nellihothe, and Raj Bhavan.

Those from the Congress camp who had filed nominations included former Minister M.O.H.F. Shahjahan from Kalapet. "I was given the forms by the AICC and the PCC leadership. There is only one candidate from the minority

community in the Congress. So far, nobody has asked me to withdraw the nomination papers. My papers have been accepted after scrutiny on Tuesday," he told *The Hindu*.

Campaign launched
By Tuesday evening, Shahjahan had launched a door-to-door campaign from Kalapet, where the DMK had also fielded a candidate – A. Senthil, alias Ramesh.

Meanwhile, leaders of the CPI, including party secretary A.M. Saleem, met DMK leaders to sort out differences in the INDIA bloc. Mr. Saleem and Member of Parliament and PCC chief V. Vaithilingam had both filed nomination papers from the Thattanchavady constituency.

Senior CPI leader N. Kalainathan had filed his nomination from the Ozhukarai constituency,

where the Congress and the VCK had also filed nominations. Apart from Ozhukarai, the VCK had filed nominations from Os-sudu and Nettapakkam, where Congress candidates had also filed nominations.

Mr. Saleem told *The Hindu* that the Thattanchavady seat was given to the party within the alliance during the 2021 election. "Further discussions are scheduled for Tuesday night. Only the DMK has initiated the talks; we are yet to hear from the Congress," he added.

DMK candidates had also filed nominations in constituencies such as Nellihothe, allotted to the Congress in past elections. The party was trying to prevail upon the candidates to withdraw their nominations by Wednesday.

CM questions PM over Centre's preparedness for West Asia war

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Preparedness for the impact of the ongoing conflict in West Asia cannot be outsourced to the people, Chief Minister M.K. Stalin said on Tuesday, questioning whether Prime Minister Narendra Modi was prepared to protect the people.

"Preparedness cannot be outsourced to the people. Prepared for what – leadership, or its absence? Who is expected to be prepared – the Union government or the people of the country?" Mr. Stalin said in a post on X.

On Monday, while briefing the Lok Sabha on the steps taken by his government to secure India's energy needs, Mr. Modi said the country should be prepared and united.

"You say that just as we

prepared for COVID-19, we must also be prepared for the impact of the West Asia war. As soon as the situation in West Asia escalated and its effects began to be felt, I wrote to you on March 11, urging you to ensure uninterrupted supply of gas cylinders for all purposes, rescue the people from Tamil Nadu stranded in Gulf countries, and revise the limits on the supply of gas to power stations," Mr. Stalin said.

On March 12, Opposition parties staged a protest in Parliament to highlight the seriousness of the situation, he said.

"On March 14, without waiting for your response, as a responsible State government, we conducted a high-level review and announced measures to handle the gas shortage, including a subsidy of ₹2 per

unit for additional electricity consumption when hotels and cloud kitchens switch from LPG to electric stoves, subsidised loans for MSMEs to purchase electric stoves and heaters, and an exemption for industries from obtaining TNPCB clearance to use alternative fuels," he said.

Mr. Stalin said that even then, he had asked the Union government what steps it would take to safeguard the interests of the people, but there had been no response.

"After all this, you advise that people must be prepared. Before asking people to be prepared, are you prepared to protect them? What precautionary measures have you taken to safeguard the people of India from the impacts of the West Asia war?" Mr. Stalin said.

Ponmudy moves Madras High Court with plea to set aside complaint over derogatory speech

Mohamed Imranullah S.
CHENNAI

DMK leader and former Minister K. Ponmudy has approached the Madras High Court with a plea to set aside a private complaint lodged against him by the BJP's Greater Chennai Corporation councillor, Uma Anandan, for comments he made in 2025, which were criticised for being offensive to Vaishnavites, Saivites, and women.

The III Metropolitan Magistrate at George Town in Chennai had taken cognisance of the private complaint, lodged for alleged offences under various provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (previously the Indian Penal Code), on February 23, 2026, and had ordered issuance of summons to the former Minister.



K. Ponmudy

In her complaint, Ms. Anandan said she came across a YouTube video of the Minister's speech, delivered at an event in Chennai in April 2025. She said it was highly distasteful, and was intended at promoting enmity between various groups, besides being prejudicial to maintenance of harmony.

She said that in the speech delivered during his stint as Forest Minister, Mr. Ponmudy had recalled

Counsel for Ponmudy said he had merely recollected what was said several decades ago, and there was no malicious intent to outrage anyone's religious feelings

an incident of a person having likened the *pattai* (a horizontal symbol displayed by Saivites on their forehead) and *tiruman* (a vertical symbol sported by Vaishnavites on their forehead) to sexual postures by a sex worker.

Since the speech amounted to wounding the religious feelings of the two sects professing Hinduism, besides falling under the definition of hate speech, the complainant initially approached the police. But the police closed her complaint, and

hence, she approached the magistrate by way of a private complaint.

Opposing her plea before the magistrate, counsel for the former Minister had contended that the complainant had not made out any offence under Sections 196(i)(a) (promoting enmity between different groups), 299 (deliberate and malicious acts intended to outrage religious feelings) or 302 (uttering words with intent to wound religious feelings) of the BNS, 2023.

It was also brought to the notice of the court that the speech was delivered in a closed hall. Counsel contended that the former Minister had merely recollected what was said several decades ago, and there was no malicious intent to outrage anyone's religious feelings.

However, after hearing

both sides, the magistrate highlighted that the former Minister had not denied making any such speech. Whether such speech would fall under the definition of hate speech, and whether the offences alleged by the complainant had been made could be decided only after a full-fledged trial, the judicial officer said.

Summons issued
"Prima facie case is made out against respondent [Mr. Ponmudy] for offences Under Sections 196(i) (a), 299, 302 of BNS, 2023. This court is inclined to take cognizance of the above said offences against the accused. Issue summons to accused," the magistrate had ordered on February 23, leading to the present plea before the High Court to set aside the private complaint.

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PM: Particulate matter pollution can cause irritation of the eyes, nose and throat, coughing, chest tightness and shortness of breath, reduced lung function, irregular heartbeats, asthma attacks, heart attacks and premature death in people with heart or lung disease.

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Cowardly bully

Trump should end the war and ask Israel to leave Iran alone

Donald Trump's decision to postpone attacks on Iran's power plants, 36 hours after issuing a 48-hour ultimatum to Tehran to reopen the Strait of Hormuz, is the clearest sign yet that the war is not going according to his plan. Over the past week, Mr. Trump has declared victory, claiming that U.S. and Israeli strikes had destroyed Iran's defence capabilities. Yet, Iran continues to launch missiles at Persian Gulf countries and Israel, while maintaining control over the Strait of Hormuz, which prevents Mr. Trump from extricating himself from a conflict whose economic costs are mounting globally. Since the war began on February 28, Iran has largely ignored Mr. Trump's threats, responding to escalation with counter-escalation. When the U.S. bombed Kharg Island, Iran struck American bases in the region. When Israel targeted South Pars, Iran hit energy facilities across Qatar, the UAE, Saudi Arabia, Kuwait and Israel. After the Natanz nuclear facility was struck, Tehran targeted Dimona, the Israeli town hosting its nuclear facilities. When Mr. Trump threatened strikes on Iran's power plants, Tehran warned of attacks on Gulf and Israeli energy assets and U.S. financial interests, forcing him to make a U-turn.

Before the war began, the U.S. and Israel had set ambitious objectives: force Tehran to shut down its nuclear programme and ship out the highly enriched uranium, cut off Iran's support for non-state militias in West Asia and dismantle its missile capabilities. Twenty-five days later, one of Mr. Trump's key priorities is to open the Strait of Hormuz, which was closed only after the war broke out. He does not have easy options to do so – he has to either talk to Tehran and make a deal or authorise a ground operation; reports suggest the U.S. has already despatched thousands of marines. Yet, Mr. Trump's U-turn on strikes on power plants indicates that he may be seriously weighing talks. Iran has dismissed Mr. Trump's claims that negotiations are underway. But President Masoud Pezeshkian has outlined conditions for ending the war: guarantees against future aggression; reparations for infrastructure damage; and recognition of Iran's 'legitimate rights' (which can be interpreted as sanctions relief). Mr. Trump, whose administration has already eased some sanctions on Iran's oil, could be looking for a deal, and Tehran could reciprocate if common ground is found. But for any diplomatic effort to progress, Mr. Trump must first rein in his ally Israel, which continues to pound Iran and Lebanon like an unhinged bully. The military path that he has embraced is showing clear limits. The least damaging way out for Mr. Trump is to strike a deal with Iran and get out of this war.

Political poker

Confusion prevails among all the main players in Puducherry

Puducherry and political confusion go together. This has been reinforced in the manner in which the major political players have gone through the seat sharing process. Though Puducherry's first NDA government, led by the AINRC and the BJP, has been able to complete its five-year term, the allies have struggled to reach an electoral understanding. An agreement was reached only on March 20, three days before nominations closed, with the AINRC and BJP allotted 16 and 10 seats, respectively, and junior allies the AIADMK and the fledgling IJK given two seats each. The AIADMK, which formed the government in 1974 and 1977, and enjoyed a vote share between 12.6% (2001) and nearly 17% (2016), faces the election as an untested force. Its woes stem from its leadership, which neglected party-building after Jayalalithaa's death. On the contrary, the BJP, once losing deposits in most of the seats it contested till 2016, rose in 2021 by allying with the AINRC, though its much-hyped "double-engine" governance model has disappointed. A 2024 study by the Union Ministry of Panchayati Raj and the IIPA highlighted Puducherry's "... most unsatisfactory" performance as there has been no panchayat election since 2006. A C&AG report on Puducherry's finances for 2023-24, also makes a few pertinent observations. Yet, Prime Minister Narendra Modi, who visited the Union Territory on March 1 to inaugurate projects worth around ₹2,700 crore, lauded the government on governance.

The Congress-DMK alliance fares no better, with differences persisting even on the final nomination day. Adding to the confusion, Puducherry MP and former Chief Minister V. Vaithilingam, also chief of the Pradesh Congress Committee, filed his nomination. Reports suggest that the Congress may contest 16 seats, leaving 12 to the DMK, and one each for the CPI and VCK. Protesting the treatment meted out to it, the VCK will contest independently in three constituencies. The CPI(M) has fielded its candidates in four seats, apart from supporting an independent in Mahe, an enclave in Kerala. Congress supporters of former Chief Minister V. Narayanasamy – he did not contest the 2021 election – are upset that he has been denied a ticket. Adding to the chaotic situation, the TVK first released a full list of 30 candidates on Sunday, the penultimate day of filing of nominations, but later announced the allotment of two seats to the fledgling NMK. At least four of the TVK's nominees are from other parties. All these political players must also account for the Union government's power to nominate three legislators to the Assembly. On April 9, nearly 9.5 lakh voters should choose a government that meaningfully improves governance and goes beyond demanding Statehood.

There are moments in public life when the familiar rhythms of governance are suddenly replaced by the need to pivot, make crucial decisions in the absence of precedent, and think on one's feet – without losing focus or compassion. The announcement of a nationwide lockdown on March 25, 2020, was one such moment. As the Chief Minister of Tamil Nadu, I found myself confronting a crisis unlike any we had experienced before, one that demanded swift decisions, constant vigilance, and, above all, a deep sense of responsibility towards every citizen.

Getting the priorities right

In those early days, as I recall, the scale of the challenge was still unfolding. We did not fully understand what we were dealing with. COVID-19 was not merely a public health emergency; it was a disruption that touched every aspect of life – health care, livelihoods, supply chains and social stability. The State had to move quickly, even as information evolved and the path ahead remained uncertain. I often say that during that period, I was a crisis manager first and a Chief Minister later. Every decision had immediate consequences, and there was little room for error.

One of the first priorities was to ensure that the health-care system was prepared. Tamil Nadu has long prided itself on a strong public health infrastructure, but the pandemic tested its limits. We expanded hospital capacity, established dedicated COVID-19 care centres, and ensured the availability of essential equipment. Doctors, nurses, sanitation workers and frontline staff became the backbone of our response. I continue to recall their courage and commitment, often in the face of personal risk, as extraordinary. This is especially relevant now, as these same workers are protesting for their basic rights and the fulfilment of promises made to them by the present ruling party.

Equally critical was the management of the lockdown itself. The sudden halt of movement posed a complex challenge: how to contain the spread of the virus while ensuring that essential goods and services remained accessible. We worked closely with district administrations to maintain supply chains, regulate markets and prevent panic. This is where being hands-on and in constant touch with administrators at the district level proved invaluable. The public distribution system played a vital role in ensuring that no family went without basic necessities. Free rations, financial assistance and targeted



Edappadi K. Palaniswami

is the General Secretary of the All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (AIADMK), Leader of the Opposition in Tamil Nadu, and was the Chief Minister of Tamil Nadu during the lockdown and COVID-19 crisis

Tamil Nadu's COVID-19 response showcased leadership, coordination, determination, and a commitment to protect lives

welfare measures were introduced to support those most affected.

What remains with me from that time is the discipline and the resilience shown by the people of Tamil Nadu. Compliance with restrictions was not always easy, particularly for daily wage earners and small business owners. Yet, there was a collective understanding that these measures were necessary. Communication became a key tool – we made it a point to provide regular updates, address concerns transparently, and build trust during a time of fear and uncertainty.

Localised decision making

Another important lesson was the value of decentralised governance. While policies were framed at the State level, their success depended on effective implementation at the district and local levels. District Collectors, police officials, health officers, and local bodies worked tirelessly, often under immense pressure. Their ability to adapt to changing circumstances ensured that the response remained agile and responsive.

At the same time, the lockdown revealed the vulnerabilities within our society. Migrant workers, informal sector labourers and small entrepreneurs were among the hardest hit. The experience reinforced the need for stronger social safety nets and more inclusive economic planning. A crisis of this magnitude does not affect all sections equally, and good governance must account for these disparities.

I am often asked what the toughest decisions were during that period. The most difficult choices involved balancing public health with economic activity. Prolonged restrictions could not be sustained indefinitely, yet premature relaxation carried its own risks. We had to calibrate our approach carefully, guided by data and expert advice. It is worth noting that when uninformed critics and detractors highlight past data to showcase their achievements, they often overlook those crucial COVID-19 years, when the phased reopening of the economy was undertaken with caution, always keeping in mind the need to protect lives while restoring livelihoods.

Technology played an important role during this period. From tracking cases to disseminating information, digital tools helped improve coordination and efficiency. However, the pandemic also highlighted the digital divide, reminding us that access to technology is not uniform and that governance must remain inclusive.

Looking back, one of the most significant

lessons is the importance of preparedness. While no state could have fully anticipated a crisis of this scale, the experience underscores the need for robust contingency planning, sustained investment in health care, and the ability to respond quickly to emerging threats. Public health must remain a priority, not only during emergencies but also as a continuous commitment.

Another lesson is the value of cooperation between governments, institutions and communities. A crisis of this nature cannot be managed in isolation. It requires coordination at multiple levels and a willingness to work together towards a common goal. Differences in political perspective must give way to a shared sense of purpose when the well-being of the people is at stake.

For me, personally, the lockdown was a period of intense responsibility and reflection. Leadership, in such times, is not about visibility but about decision-making, which is often difficult, sometimes unpopular, but always guided by the larger public interest. It is about remaining calm under pressure, listening to experts, and staying connected to realities on the ground.

The management of the lockdown in Tamil Nadu may not always have been widely spoken about, but it was marked by quiet efficiency and a collective effort that deserves recognition. It was not the work of any one individual, but of an entire system that came together in the face of an unprecedented challenge.

Upon reflection

Today marks six years since the lockdown was imposed in India. We have, in many ways, left those difficult days behind. Masking is now largely a thing of the past, and the economy is on an upward trajectory. Yet, as we move forward, it is important not to lose sight of these lessons. The pandemic has left an enduring impact, but it has also provided an opportunity to strengthen our systems, rethink our priorities, and build a more resilient future.

History will remember this period not only for the challenges it posed, but also for the way we responded to them. Crisis comes unannounced, and when it does, it is experience, a calm head, and deep compassion for people that guide our decisions.

In Tamil Nadu, that response was defined by determination, coordination, and a shared commitment to protect lives.

And that, perhaps, is the most important lesson of all.

Deepening global corruption as a pointer for India

The Corruption Perceptions Index 2025 (CPI) published by Transparency International delivers an unmistakable message. Corruption is not receding. It is deepening in ways that erode democratic accountability and hollow out public institutions. For the first time in over a decade, the global average score has dropped to 42 out of 100, with 122 of 182 countries scoring below 50. Only five countries now score above 80, compared with 12 a decade ago. The direction is clear and troubling. Where oversight weakens and civic freedoms narrow, corruption perceptions worsen.

What the data show

India's position must be assessed within this global decline. With a score of 39 and a rank of 91 out of 182 countries in the 2025 index, India remains in the lower half of the table. Over the past decade, India's score has fluctuated narrowly between 38 and 41. In 2014, it stood at 38. A decade later, it remains broadly similar. For a country that has emerged as the world's fourth-largest economy and aspires to achieve developed nation status by 2047, this stagnation is revealing. While the economic scale has expanded dramatically over time, the governance perception has not kept pace.

Global comparisons sharpen the picture. China scores 42. Sri Lanka stands close to India's level, while Bangladesh and Pakistan score lower. India performs better than some of its neighbours, yet it trails several upper-middle-income democracies and many East Asian and European countries that once operated at comparable development levels. Those countries strengthened institutional independence, transparency frameworks and regulatory predictability over time. Their CPI trajectories reflect sustained reform.

Why does India's CPI score matter? First, the index measures perceived public sector integrity rather than recorded incidents. It draws on 13 independent data sources that assess public procurement, regulatory enforcement, judicial effectiveness and institutional safeguards. A score of 39 signals persistent weaknesses in



Saumitra Bhaduri

is Professor at the Madras School of Economics, researches financial economics and econometrics, development economics and policy analysis, and has published widely in international journals

Transparency must become a national priority as governance credibility is now a competitive economic variable

transparency, oversight and accountability. Perceptions influence investment decisions, sovereign risk assessments and long-term capital allocation. Governance credibility has now become a competitive economic variable.

Second, corruption carries measurable economic costs. It increases transaction uncertainty, raises compliance expenses and diverts entrepreneurial energy toward navigating rent-seeking systems rather than creating value. These distortions reduce productivity and discourage investment. A widely cited global estimate suggests that corruption costs at least 5% of global GDP annually, equivalent to more than \$2.6 trillion in lost output each year. This figure includes bribes, illicit financial flows and inefficiencies in public spending. While precise quantification varies across studies, the scale of the drag is undeniable.

For developing economies such as India, the impact is significant. Research linked to multilateral institutions suggests that corruption may cost India roughly 0.5% of GDP annually in direct terms, with broader estimates placing total losses between 1% and 1.5% of GDP once indirect growth effects are included. At current output levels, this represents tens of billions of dollars each year. These are resources that could finance infrastructure, health, education or industrial upgrading.

Hurdles in compliance architecture

A third structural concern lies in the complexity of India's compliance architecture. A recent report indicates that entrepreneurs operate under the shadow of 26,134 imprisonment provisions embedded across India's business regulations. The scale of the burden becomes clearer at the industry level. Even as the Union Budget 2026-27 proposes the Biopharma Strategy for Healthcare Advancement through Knowledge, Technology and Innovation (SHAKTI) initiative with an allocation of ₹10,000 crore over five years, a pharmaceutical start-up with a single manufacturing unit is required to navigate 998 separate compliance obligations before commencing operations, with nearly 49% bearing potential criminal liability. Such extensive

criminalisation within regulatory frameworks not only raises the cost of doing business but also expands discretionary power in ways that can inadvertently create conditions for rent seeking.

Encouraging trends

Yet, the picture is not uniformly bleak, as there are also positive counter-currents. India's digital public infrastructure has reduced leakages in certain welfare schemes through direct benefit transfers linked to bank accounts and digital identity. The Reserve Bank of India's Digital Payments Index (RBI-DPI), with March 2018 as the base, has been tracking the extent of digitisation of payments across the country since January 1, 2021. The index for September 2025 stands at 516.76 as against 493.22 for March 2025. The Goods and Services Tax network has increased formalisation and traceability in indirect taxation.

E-procurement portals and digital payment systems have reduced opportunities for some forms of rent seeking. These reforms demonstrate that institutional design and the use of technology can reduce discretion. Corruption, therefore, is not merely a moral or legal problem. It is an economic constraint and a strategic vulnerability. It weakens fiscal efficiency, undermines regulatory credibility and reduces social trust. For a country that envisions becoming a \$10 trillion- economy within the next decade, governance quality cannot remain static. Rapid economic expansion without parallel institutional strengthening creates an imbalance.

The 2025 Index should be read as a benchmark rather than a verdict. India possesses strong constitutional foundations, competitive elections, a capable judiciary and growing digital capacity. Even modest but sustained improvements in transparency, judicial efficiency, regulatory simplification and institutional independence could materially improve perceptions over time. Countries that climbed the CPI rankings did so through cumulative reform, not episodic crackdowns.

India's economic ascent has been decisive. Its governance evolution must now match that ambition with equal resolve.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

War 'breather'

The sudden 'pause' in the West Asia conflict offers a much-needed, though uncertain, reprieve amid the prolonged U.S.-Israel strikes on Iran (Front page, March 24). The aimless military aggression has also inflicted widespread devastation in the Gulf region. There has also been a frequent shifting of goalposts by the

United States. With the unilateral announcement of an abrupt pause, it is still hazy whether Israel and the U.S. are on the same page. Further, given the veracity of Mr. Trump's assurances earlier, it remains to be seen whether the 'peace rhetoric' that he has chosen can yield tangible results in cessation of war. Perhaps India can leverage its core

diplomatic strengths — its bonhomie with Israel and friendly bilateral relations with Iran and the Gulf nations — in forging a durable peace in the region. **G. Ramasubramanyam,** Vijayawada, Andhra Pradesh

The war between U.S.-Israel and Iran has caused immense suffering throughout the world.

However, it is welcome news to acknowledge the possibility of a truce deal. The UN must step in and facilitate dialogue between the warring nations. Regional intergovernmental organisations too must step up efforts to secure the trade of oil and gas and also prevent further escalations. **Manas Agarwal,** Shahjahanpur, Uttar Pradesh

Impact on small investors The turbulence in Indian equity markets ever since the West Asia conflict began has hit small retail investors disproportionately hard. Unlike institutional players with hedging tools and diversified portfolios, the individual investor who entered the market during the post-COVID-19 boom often has neither the

knowledge nor the liquidity buffer to ride out sustained volatility. What he needs now is practical guidance. Systematic investment plans, spread across debt and equity, remain the most sensible instruments.

A. Myilsami, Coimbatore

Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

Business

INBRIEF



New India Assurance gets ₹189.37 cr I-T demand order

New India Assurance Company has been issued an assessment order by the Income Tax Department asking it to pay more than ₹189.37 crore. The order for ₹1,89,37,08,470 is for AY 2023-24 and issued by the National Faceless e Assessment Center disallowing certain expenses, New India Assurance said in a filing on Tuesday. The company said it would pursue an appeal before NFAC or other legal options against the said order.

HDFC Life Insurance gets Income Tax order for ₹172 cr.

HDFC Life Insurance Company has received an Income Tax order asking it to pay a little over ₹172 crore. Consisting of ₹126.46 crore tax demand, ₹45.55 crore interest and nil penalty, the order from the Income Tax authorities in Mumbai is for Assessment Year 2023-24 (financial year 2022-23) and related to multiple alleged violations. The company will file an appeal before the Appellate Authority, HDFC Life said in a filing on Tuesday.

Raajmarg Infra Investment Trust gets listed on the BSE

The National Highways Authority of India's (NHAI) Raajmarga Infrastructure Investment Trust (RIIT) was listed on the BSE on Tuesday, in the presence of Union Road Transport and Highways Minister Nitin Gadkari. The InvIT is aimed at widening investor participation in the highway infra sector. Calling the listing a “significant milestone,” Mr. Gadkari said the issue saw strong demand, with subscriptions reaching nearly 14 times the offer size.

Manipal Health to raise ₹8,000 crore via IPO

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

Manipal Health Enterprise Ltd., backed by Singapore's Temasek, has filed Draft Red Herring Prospectus (DRHP) with SEBI on Tuesday to raise ₹8,000 crore through an IPO.

The IPO also comprises offer-for-sale of up to 43,227,668 equity shares by promoters viz. Imperius Healthcare Investments, Manipal Education and Medial Group India and existing investors, including TPG and Novo Holdings.

The proceeds would mainly be used to repay debt with ₹5,378 crore for repayment in full or part of outstanding borrowings/ accrued interest availed by Manipal Hospitals Pvt. Ltd.

AC firms stare at war induced plastic pinch

The Hindu Bureau
HYDERABAD

Air-conditioner firms in India are looking forward to FY27 with hope as West Asia war threatens to hit plastic component availability and consumer sentiment, adding to the challenges around input prices and new energy label, a top company official said.

Difficult to get

Lots of plastic components are becoming difficult to get in the backdrop of the war impact on crude supplies. The additional price increase on this count though is early to assess for the AC makers feeling the

MSL mulls ₹10,189-cr. capacity expansion

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

The board of Maruti Suzuki India Ltd. (MSL) approved addition of first phase of capacity of 2,50,000 vehicles per annum at Khoraj Industrial Estate in Gujarat involving an investment of ₹10,189 crore which will be met via internal accruals.

The additional capacity would help meet demand growth, including exports.

Common infrastructure

“This includes investment for the first phase of car manufacturing plant having an annual manufacturing capacity of 2,50,000 units and some common infrastructure and facilities for future plants,” the company said.

The company's total existing capacity is about 24



The additional capacity would help meet demand growth.

lakh units per annum at Gurugram, Manesar, Kharkhoda and Hansalpur, with a capability to produce 26 lakh units per annum.

This includes the units produced at erstwhile Suzuki Motor Gujarat Private Limited which has been amalgamated with the Company. The existing capacity is fully utilised, according to the company.

JSL starts Indonesia steel melt shop

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

Jindal Stainless Ltd (JSL) said it commissioned the 1.2 million tonne per annum (MTPA) stainless steel melt shop (SMS) in Indonesia, developed through the company's joint venture, ahead of schedule.

JSL's total melting capacity will hence be ramped up to 4.2 MTPA, including 3 MTPA in India.

JSL said it was also gearing up to commission a new 1.1 MTPA Hot Rolled Annealed Pickled (HRAP) line and 0.17 MTPA Cold Rolling capacity in Jaipur and Odisha by Q4FY27 and Q2FY27 respectively.

Nasscom honours 25 SMEs for innovation

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

India's technology small and medium enterprises (SMEs) are currently at a pivotal moment, actively rebuilding growth models, re-imagining capabilities and redefining talent strategies for an AI-shaped world, said Srikanth Srinivasan, VP and head, membership and outreach at Nasscom on Tuesday.

Nasscom on Tuesday recognised 25 small and medium enterprises for significant contributions to India's technology SME ecosystem. These enterprises, winners of the 4th edition of the SME Inspire Awards 2026, were recognised for excellence, innovation and resilience.

To further boost cold rolling capacities, JSL earmarked a sum of ₹900 crore at Hisar and Kharagpur

This development is part of the earlier announced outlay of ₹ 1,900 crore. To further boost cold rolling capacities, JSL earmarked ₹900 crore at Hisar and Kharagpur, which are expected to be commissioned by Q2FY28.

The new and expanded downstream facilities will enable the production of thinner cold rolled products tailored for high-growth industries.

Mahanagar Gas woos LPG users for PNG shift

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

Mahanagar Gas Ltd. (MGL), a City Gas Distribution (CGD) company, stepped up efforts to shift customers using LPG to Piped Natural Gas (PNG) offering uninterrupted

supply and sops. It is also offering Compressed Natural Gas (CNG) for transport across its geographical areas (GAs) in Maharashtra and Karnataka. In line with the Natural Gas (Supply Regulation) Order 2026, domestic PNG and CNG

have been recognised as the highest priority sector.

MGL has taken steps for consistent supply to ensure clients get reliable and safe fuel for daily use. Alongside, MGL unveiled customer-focused initiatives to hasten PNG adop-

tion in the GAs, including offering free gas worth ₹500 to all new registrations and ₹1,000 adjustment in gas bills from new buildings where penetration is over 60%.

For commercial customers, MGL is waiving registration charges.

राजस्थान राज्य पाट्र्यपुस्तक मण्डल, जयपुर

2-2ए झालाना इंग्लिश जयपुर

फोन 0141-2711237, 2703657, 2700540 फैक्स: 0141-2710362

email: secretary.rstb@rajasthan.gov.in

CORRIGENDUM

बिड संख्या 369 दिनांक 05.03.2026 में विभिन्न दिनांकों में संशोधन किया गया जिसका विवरण राजकीय पोर्टल / वेबसाइट <https://sppp.rajasthan.gov.in> और <https://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in> पर देखा जा सकता है।

शेष शर्तें यथावत रहेंगी।

राज.संवाद / सी / 25 / 23127

सचिव

PARADIP PORT AUTHORITY
ADMINISTRATIVE DEPARTMENT

e-TENDER CALL NOTICE No. AD/SH-189/25/Inv/016
Dtd. 17.03.2026

Name of the work-“Providing Hospitality services to Jawahar Guest House, Sector-21, Paradip and PPA Guest House, Bhubaneswar”. Estimated cost put to tender ₹ 3,01,60,961.00 (excluding GST @18% & Contractor's Commission). The last date & time of submission of bid is 30.03.2026 upto 1700 Hrs. for details please refer our website : www.paradipport.gov.in/ <https://eprocure.gov.in/eprocure/app>.

Asst. Secretary (Admn.), PPA
PPA/PR/76/2025-26, dt.24/03/2026

RAIL WHEEL FACTORY
Yelahanka, BANGALORE - 560 064
Website: www.rwf.indianrailways.gov.in

Tender Notice No. RWF/S/P/22/2025-26
Dated 23/03/2026

On behalf of the President of India, the Principal Chief Materials Manager invites Electronic Open Tender for supply of the following item, on the Indian Railways e-portal www.irpsps.gov.in.

Tender Number and Brief Item Description : P2255913B, Magnesia Spinel Brick Set for Ladle Lining as per RWF Specification. (Developmental Tender). **Quantity :** 25 Sets. **Tender Closing Date and Time :** 09/04/2026, 14:00 hrs.

TENDER NOTICE NO./RWF/S/P/1/02/ 2025-26 dt:24.03.2026

Tender Number and Brief Item Description : P1261178, Tin coated Spiral machine Taps. **Quantity :** 1400 Nos. **Due Date :** 10/04/2026.

Tender details can be viewed on our website www.rwf.indianrailways.gov.in or www.irpsps.gov.in. The tender documents and the corrigendum to the Tender if any, will be available on the portal only.

Principal Chief Materials Manager

PUNJAB STATE GRAINS PROCUREMENT CORPORATION LIMITED ANAAJ BHAWAN, SECTOR 39-C, CHANDIGARH

Notice Inviting Tender

PUNGRAIN invites bids under two bid system i.e. Technical and Financial bids from eligible bidders interested for engagement as Service Provider(s) to provide Preservation, Maintenance, and Security (PMS) services for food grains stored in PEG godowns constructed & hired/ to be constructed & hired by PUNGRAIN & MARKFED on 'lease only basis' under Private Entrepreneur Guarantee 2008 scheme of GOI/FCI; covered godowns owned/ hired by the State Procuring Agencies i.e. PUNGRAIN, PUNSUP, and MARKFED & further leased to FCI on GHB basis for storage of rice and CAP (Cover and Plinth) constructed & hired/ to be hired on 'lease only basis' by PUNGRAIN under CAP hiring Scheme-2019.

For details log onto: <https://eproc.punjab.gov.in> or <http://foodsuppb.gov.in>

Bid submission period: From 02:00 PM on 25.03.2026 till 3:00 PM on 09.04.2026.

Pre-bid Conference: On 30.03.2026 at 11:00 AM in the O/o PUNGRAIN, Committee room, Anaj Bhawan, Sector 39-C, Chandigarh.

Technical Bid Opening date & time: At 04:00 PM on 09.04.2026.

Note: 1. PUNGRAIN reserves the right to scrap the tender at any stage without assigning any reason thereof.
2. Any addendum/corrigendum(s) to the tender shall be published on the above websites only.

1027/12/2025-26/9833

Managing Director, PUNGRAIN

सीएसआईआर-संरचनात्मक अभियांत्रिकी अनुसंधान केंद्र

CSIR-STRUCTURAL ENGINEERING RESEARCH CENTRE

(वैज्ञानिक तथा औद्योगिक अनुसंधान परिषद् Council of Scientific & Industrial Research)

सीएसआईआर परिसर CSIR Campus, तम्रमनी, चेन्नै Chennai - 600 113, भारत INDIA

दूरभाष Tel : 044 - 2254 9108 / 4777, 22541238 फैक्स Fax : 044-22542211

ई-मेल E-mail : puroff.hsrc@csir.res.in

जिस किसी से भी यह संबंधित हो TO WHOMSOEVER IT MAY CONCERN

यह सूचित किया जाता है कि ग्राहकों से प्राप्त कुछ परीक्षण सामग्री वर्ष 2006-2011 की अवधि के दौरान प्राप्त हुई थी, जो 10 वर्षों से अधिक समय से सीएसआईआर-एसआईआरसी, टीटीआरएस, पल्लवारम, चेन्नई परिसर में पड़ी हुई है तथा स्थान घेर रही है।

It is informed that certain testing materials received from clients are lying in the campus (CSIR-SERC, TTTRS, Pallavaram, Chennai) for more than 10 years (during the period 2006 - 2011) and occupying space.

संबंधित ग्राहकों को सलाह दी जाती है कि वे इस नोटिस के जारी होने की तिथि से 30 दिनों के भीतर उपरोक्त परिसर से अपनी परीक्षण सामग्री, जमा करने का प्रमाण प्रस्तुत करते हुए, हटा लें। अन्यथा उक्त सामग्री को अदावी सामग्री माना जाएगा तथा सीएसआईआर एसआईआरसी द्वारा उसकी नीलामी कर दी जाएगी। इसके पश्चात किसी भी प्रकार का कोई दावा स्वीकार नहीं किया जाएगा।

The respective clients are advised to remove their testing material from the above campus within 30 days of this notice by showing proof of submission, failing which it will be treated as unclaimed goods and will be auctioned by CSIR-SERC. No claim of any kind shall be entertained after that.

अधिक जानकारी के लिए कृपया हमारी वेबसाइट देखें : <https://serc.res.in>

For details please visit our website : <https://serc.res.in>

मंडार एवं क्रय नियंत्रक

Controller of Stores & Purchase

BEIRUT

Lebanon withdraws Iran envoy's accreditation, orders him to leave



Lebanon's Foreign Ministry said on Tuesday it had withdrawn its approval of the Iranian ambassador Mohammad Reza Sheibani's accreditation, giving him until Sunday to leave the country. It had also summoned Lebanon's ambassador to Iran "in light of what Lebanon described as Tehran's violation of diplomatic norms". AFP

ABIDJAN

New jihadist attack on military post in Burkina kills 14 soldiers



A jihadist attack on a military post killed at least 14 soldiers in northern Burkina Faso, which has seen a flare-up in violence in recent weeks, security officials said on Tuesday. Al-Qaeda's branch in the Sahel, the Group for the Support of Islam and Muslims (JNIM), claimed responsibility for the attack in Bagade on Saturday. AFP

GENEVA

'More than 500 civilians killed in drone strikes this year in Sudan'



More than 500 civilians were killed in drone strikes in Sudan between January and mid-March, with the vast majority killed in the strategic Kordofan region, the United Nations said on Tuesday. Kordofan region is currently the fiercest battlefield in the three-year war between the regular army and the Rapid Support Forces. AFP

WASHINGTON

Senate confirms Markwayne Mullin to lead Homeland Security



The Senate confirmed Markwayne Mullin as Homeland Security secretary late Monday, approving U.S. President Donald Trump's nominee to take over the embattled department after the firing of Kristi Noem during a public backlash over the administration's immigration enforcement and mass deportation operations. AP

Iran, Israel trade strikes despite Trump's claims of negotiations

Israel carries out a 'large wave' of air strikes across Iran's territory, hitting what it calls military 'production sites' and energy infrastructure; Iranian missiles and drones strike Tel Aviv, wounding four; Tehran reports more than 1,500 dead in the war

Associated Press
DUBAI

Air strikes battered Iran, and Iranian missiles and drones targeted Israel's Tel Aviv and sites across the West Asia on Tuesday, even as President Donald Trump said the United States was in talks with the Islamic Republic to end the war.

With thousands more U.S. Marines on their way to the Gulf, both sides firing barrages and Iran denying any negotiations are taking place, the war's tempo remained high a day after Mr. Trump delayed his self-imposed dea-



Retaliatory strike: Israeli emergency service personnel gather at the site of an Iranian missile strike in Tel Aviv on Tuesday. AFP

dline for Iran to reopen the Strait of Hormuz. Tehran's chokehold on that crucial waterway has snarled international shipping, sent fuel prices skyrocketing,

and threatened the world economy. Pakistan offered to host diplomatic talks, but Iran remained defiant, vowing to fight "until complete victory".

Israel's army on Tuesday said it had conducted a "large wave" of air strikes across several areas of Iran, which had earlier launched a "direct hit" on a building in an upscale area of Tel Aviv. It added that it carried out an extensive series of strikes on Iranian "production sites," without providing more information.

Iranian media reported that Israeli-U.S. strikes targeted two gas facilities and a pipeline. "As part of the ongoing attacks carried out by the Zionist and American enemy, the gas administration building and the gas pressure regulation station on Kaveh Street in Isfa-

han were targeted," the *Fars* news agency said. It added that an attack also targeted the gas pipeline of the Khorramshahr plant. Iran's death toll has surpassed 1,500, its Health Ministry has said.

Iran also fired multiple waves of missiles at Israel. In Tel Aviv, a missile with a 100 kg warhead slammed into the city centre, blowing out windows of an apartment building. Four persons suffered minor wounds, rescue service workers said. Late on Tuesday, Israeli emergency services said a woman was killed in the north of the country following rocket fire from Lebanon.

Ex-Guardsman Zolqadr is Iran's new security chief

Stanly Johny

Mohammad Baqer Zolqadr, a veteran commander of the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC), has been appointed as the new Secretary of Iran's Supreme National Security Council.

Mr. Zolqadr, who currently serves as the secretary of Expediency Dis-cernment Council, an advisory body to the Supreme Leader, replaces Ali Larijani, who was assassinated by an Israeli strike on March 17.

"Zolqadr has been appointed to the top security chair by a direct presidential decree and with the endorsement of Leader of the Islamic Revolution Ayatollah Seyyed Mojtaba Khamenei," state-run Press TV reported.



Mohammad Baqer Zolqadr

He previously served as deputy chief of the General Staff of the Armed Forces for Basij, a paramilitary organisation, and held senior positions in the judiciary.

Larijani, one of the most influential non-clerical politicians in Iran, had emerged as the face of the country's defiance after the U.S. and Israel started a war on Iran on February 28, assassinating Supreme Leader Ali Khamenei.

Mr. Zolqadr, who fought the 1980-88 war against Saddam Hussein's Iraq, headed the IRGC Joint Staff for eight years during the presidency of Akbar Hashemi Rafsanjani.

In 2005, after Mahmoud Ahmadinejad became President, Mr. Zolqadr was named Deputy Interior Minister for security and police. He became an adviser to Chief Justice Sadeq Larijani in 2010, and appointed the deputy Judiciary chief for strategic affairs on 14 May 2012. He became the Secretary of the powerful Expediency Council in 2023, when Ebrahim Raisi was the President.

As the secretary of the Security Council, Mr. Zolqadr will play a key role in decision making at a time when Iran is at war against the U.S. and Israel.

Israel to 'take control of security zone' up to Litani in Lebanon

Agence France-Presse
JERUSALEM

Israeli Defence Minister Israel Katz said on Tuesday that the military would take control of south Lebanon all the way to the Litani River.

"All five bridges over the Litani that were used by Hezbollah for the passage of terrorists and weapons have been blown up, and the IDF (Israeli military) will control the rest of the bridges and the security zone up to the Litani," Mr. Katz said during a visit to a military command centre in Israel.

The military said it had destroyed a bridge across the Litani river overnight,

which it says was used by Iran-backed Lebanese militant group Hezbollah "for transferring weapons, rockets and launchers".

Mr. Katz added that the hundreds of thousands of south Lebanon residents who were displaced by the West Asia war this month "will not return south of the Litani River until security is guaranteed for the residents of the north" of Israel.

Meanwhile, Lebanon's Health Ministry said that an Israeli strike on Bshamoun, south of Beirut, killed two persons on Tuesday, while strikes on the capital's southern suburbs continued throughout the night.

Brains and brawn



Athletes attempt to control a zebu that has been brought into an arena during a Savika Omby competition in Antananarivo. Savika Omby, a form of bullfighting, is a traditional Malagasy sport most often practised in rural areas on the Highlands of Madagascar. AFP

Russia fires over 400 drones at Ukraine; four killed, 27 injured

Associated Press
KYIV

A major Russian drone and missile attack on civilian areas of Ukraine killed four persons and injured at least 27, officials said on Tuesday, while Moscow's army stepped up efforts to break through Ukrainian front-line defences in what could be the start of an anticipated spring ground offensive.

Russia fired almost 400 long-range drones at Ukraine overnight, Ukraine's air force said, in its biggest attack in weeks. The onslaught continued into Tuesday morning as dozens of drones targeted the capital Kyiv during



A building in Lviv on fire after a Russian missile strike. AP

daylight. Russia also launched 23 cruise missiles and seven ballistic missiles at Ukraine during the night, hitting at least 10 locations across the country, according to the air force. Russia has escalated its strikes on Ukraine since March 17.

China maps the ocean floor as it prepares for submarine warfare with U.S.

Reuters
SYDNEY

China is conducting a vast undersea mapping and monitoring operation across the Pacific, Indian and Arctic oceans, building detailed knowledge of marine conditions that naval experts say would be crucial for waging submarine warfare against the United States and its allies.

In one example, the *Dong Fang Hong 3*, a research vessel operated by Ocean University of China, spent 2024 and 2025 sailing back and forth in the seas near Taiwan and the U.S. stronghold of Guam, and around strategic stretches of the Indian Ocean, ship-tracking data reviewed by *Reuters* shows. In October 2024, it checked on a set of power-

ful Chinese ocean sensors capable of identifying undersea objects near Japan, according to Ocean University, and visited the same area again last May. And in March 2025, it criss-crossed the waters between Sri Lanka and Indonesia, covering approaches to the Malacca Strait, a critical chokepoint for maritime commerce.

According to the university, the ship was carrying out mud surveys and climate research. But a scientific paper co-written by Ocean University academics shows it has also conducted extensive deep-sea mapping. Naval-warfare experts and U.S. Navy officials say the type of deep-sea data being collected by the *Dong Fang Hong 3* - via mapping and placement of sensors in the ocean - is

giving China a picture of the subsea conditions it would need to deploy its submarines more effectively and hunt down those of its adversaries.

The *Dong Fang Hong 3* isn't operating alone. It is part of a broader ocean mapping and monitoring operation involving dozens of research vessels and hundreds of sensors. In tracing this effort, *Reuters* examined Chinese government and university records, including journal articles and scientific studies, and analysed more than five years of movement by 42 research vessels active in the Pacific, Indian or Arctic oceans using a ship-tracking platform built by New Zealand company Starboard Maritime Intelligence.

While the research has



Dong Fang Hong 3, a deep-sea research vessel, docks at a pier in Qingdao, Shandong province, China. REUTERS

civilian purposes - some of the surveying covers fishing grounds or areas where China has mineral prospecting contracts - it also serves a military one, according to nine naval-warfare experts who reviewed *Reuters*' findings.

To gather information about underwater terrain,

research vessels map the sea floor while travelling back and forth in tight lines. The tracking data shows that type of movement by the vessels *Reuters* tracked across large sections of the Pacific, Indian and Arctic oceans.

At least eight of the vessels *Reuters* tracked have

conducted seabed mapping, while another 10 have carried equipment used for mapping, according to a review of Chinese state media articles, vessel descriptions published by Chinese universities, and press releases by government organisations.

The vessels' survey data "would be potentially invaluable in preparation of the battlespace" for Chinese submarines, said Peter Scott, a former chief of Australia's submarine force. "Any military submariner worth his salt will put a great deal of effort in to understanding the environment he's operating in."

The ship-tracking data show that China's seabed surveying effort is focused in part on militarily important waters around the Phi-

lippines, near Guam and Hawaii, and near U.S. military facilities on Wake atoll in the north Pacific.

"The scale of what they're doing is about more than just resources," said Jennifer Parker, an adjunct professor of defence and security at the University of Western Australia and former Australian anti-submarine warfare officer. "If you look at the sheer extent of it, it's very clear that they intend to have an expeditionary blue-water naval capability that also is built around submarine operations."

In testimony to a congressional commission this month, Rear Admiral Mike Brookes, the commander of the U.S. Office of Naval Intelligence, said China had dramatically expanded its surveying efforts,

providing data that "enables submarine navigation, concealment, and positioning of seabed sensors or weapons". He added that "potential military intelligence collection" by Chinese research vessels "represents a strategic concern". America recently overhauled its own efforts to map and monitor the ocean, but it typically does so with military vessels that are allowed to turn off the tracking system monitored by civilian software. China's civilian survey ships also sometimes disable tracking, meaning its campaign may go further than *Reuters* could determine. This is the first time the extent of China's mapping and monitoring across the Pacific, Indian and Arctic oceans has been reported.

PAYING TRIBUTE

RCB to wear #11 jersey and leave 11 seats empty in honour of victims



FILE PHOTO: K. BHAGYA PRAKASH

The Royal Challengers Bengaluru players will sport jersey No. 11 in the warm-up session ahead of the IPL season's first match against Sunrisers Hyderabad on March 28. The defending champion also plans to keep 11 seats empty in honour of the fans who died in a stampede outside the M. Chinnaswamy Stadium last year.

LATE WITHDRAWAL

DC opener Duckett pulls out of IPL to focus on red-ball cricket



REUTERS

Delhi Capitals opener Ben Duckett has decided to pull out of IPL 2026. As per the amended rules, the Englishman will face a two-year ban from the league and auction. Duckett was acquired by Capitals for ₹2 crore in the mini auction, but the 31-year-old now wants to spend time at home and play red-ball cricket.

REPLACEMENTS

CSK brings in Johnson in place of injured Ellis; SRH signs Payne



FILE PHOTO

CSK has signed Australia left-arm pacer Spencer Johnson, *in pic.*, as a replacement for Nathan Ellis, who was ruled out of the IPL due to a hamstring injury. Johnson recently pulled out of the PSL and will join CSK for ₹1.5 crore. Meanwhile, SRH has named England pacer David Payne as replacement for the injured Jack Edwards.

SHUTTLE TIME

Lakshya, Sindhu to lead the Indian challenge in Thomas & Uber Cup



SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

The squad: Men: Lakshya Sen, Ayush Shetty, K. Srikanth, H.S. Prannoy, Kiran George, Satwiksairaj Rankireddy, Chirag Shetty, A. Hariharan, M.R. Arjun, Dhruv Kapila. **Women:** P.V. Sindhu, Unnati Hooda, Tanvi Sharma, Devika Sihag, Isharani Baruah, Treasa Jolly, Gayatri Gopichand, Kavipriya Selvam, Simran Singh, Tanisha Crasto.

Tackling resource crunch a big task for Knight Riders

The Kolkata team's bowling department looks depleted after injuries to medium-pacers Harshit and Akash Deep; the strong batting unit has the wherewithal to make up lost ground

Y.B. Sarangi

Even before beginning its IPL 2026 campaign, a formidable-looking Kolkata Knight Riders has run into bumps in the road due to injuries to some of its key pacers.

With Akash Deep ruled out, Harshit Rana's participation doubtful and Sri Lankan Matheesha Pathirana — a high-value asset who commanded ₹18 crore in the mini-auction — recovering from a calf strain, Knight Riders' pace department faces a resource crunch.

Muzarabani a Blessing

In such a scenario, all-rounder Cameron Green, the Kolkata outfit's costliest acquisition, will play a vital role.

Zimbabwe's Muzarabani, who replaced Mustafizur Rahman, can prove to be a Blessing because of the form he is in — the pacer scalped 13 wickets in the T20 World Cup.

The three-time champion's Indian fast-bowling recruits, the dependable Vaibhav Arora and the pro-



CHAMPION 2012 2014 2024

IPL-19 COUNTDOWN

Kolkata Knight Riders

OVERALL NUMBERS

	M	W	L	NR
265	136	127	2	

BY OPPONENT

	M	W	L	NR
CSK	31	11	20	0
DC	34	19	15	0
GT	4	1	3	0
LSG	6	2	4	0
MI	35	11	24	0
PBKS	35	21	13	1
RCB	35	20	15	0
RR	31	16	14	1
SRH	30	20	10	0

Knight Riders' remaining matches were against Deccan Chargers (9), PWI (5), GL (4), RPS (4) and KTK (2)

KKR's 2026 LEAGUE CAMPAIGN*

March 29	vs. MI	Mumbai	7.30 p.m.
April 2	vs. SRH	Kolkata	7.30 p.m.
April 6	vs. PBKS	Kolkata	7.30 p.m.
April 9	vs. LSG	Kolkata	7.30 p.m.

*announced so far

MIRACLE MAN

Cameron Green: KKR will look to make best use of the 26-year-old all-rounder, who became the most expensive overseas player in the IPL with a whopping ₹25.20 crore price tag. Even though the towering Aussie, with a batting strike rate of 148.36, looks an ideal replacement for Andre Russell, he could play a different role. As the Kolkata outfit is struggling with injuries to some of its speedsters, Green could be a key component in the pace department.

THE SQUAD

Ajinkya Rahane (Capt.), Rinku Singh (Vice-capt.), Angkrish Raghuvanshi, Cameron Green, Manish Pandey, Rahul Tripathi, Ramandeep Singh, Anukul Roy, Daksh Kamra, Rachin Ravindra, Rovman Powell, Sarthak Ranjan, Sunil Narine, Finn Allen, Tejasvi Singh, Tim Seifert, Blessing Muzarabani, Kartik Tyagi, Matheesha Pathirana, Prashant Solanki, Umran Malik, Vaibhav Arora, Varun Chakravarthy and Saurabh Dube.

COMPILED BY G. PRASAD & Y.B. SARANGI



Growing in stature: Rinku, left, will have the additional responsibility of being the vice-captain. PTI

Rahane in the top-three.

As the leader, Rahane, KKR's top run-getter last season (390 with a strike rate of almost 148), got mixed reviews as the side struggled after its crowning glory and missed its 2024 title-winning captain Shreyas Iyer. But the former India Test skipper is up for the challenge.

Angkrish Raghuvanshi and Green, part of the middle-order, are expected to

provide the impetus. Rinku Singh, whose role will be critical, and Raman-deep Singh are likely to wear the 'finisher' hats.

Where will Narine bat?

While Rahul Tripathi remains a good back-up, Narine needs to be given a slot where he can execute his pinch-hitting ability and annoy the opposition.

KKR will look to put up big scores at Eden Gardens

to maximise its home advantage and give itself a better chance of making it to the playoffs despite the odds.

Handling mini-crisis

With fine cricketing brains operating its think-tank, Knight Riders should find a way out of the mini-crisis quickly as it may play most of its home matches prior to the impending state elections in late April.



Big blow: Dayal, who was retained by RCB for ₹5 crore, will have to sit out the high-profile competition. FILE PHOTO: K. MURALI KUMAR

Dayal won't play for RCB in IPL 2026: Bobat

Ashwin Achal
BENGALURU

Royal Challengers Bengaluru (RCB) pacer Yash Dayal will not be a part of the side for IPL 2026, RCB director of cricket Mo Bobat said here on Tuesday.

Bobat added that Dayal, who faces legal issues, remains under contract with RCB, and has the support of the franchise as he "goes through his personal situation".

"Yash will not be joining up with the squad. He is going through a personal situation currently. We've been very supportive of Yash to date. We wanted to retain him, and he remains under contract and will continue, in the short term, foreseeable (future) to remain under contract. It has been decided that it is not in his best interest, or the franchise's best interest, for him to join up with us at this point," Bobat said in a press conference.

"He obviously retains our support, he remains under contract, and we'll

continue to speak to him as he goes through his personal situation," Bobat said.

Dayal's last competitive match was the IPL 2025 final, after which RCB retained him for ₹5 crore.

RCB will continue to wait on fast bowler Josh Hazlewood to regain full fitness. Bobat did not reveal a timeline on Hazlewood's expected return. "Josh is currently working through a 'return-to-play' programme in Australia. We are liaising very closely with both Josh and Cricket Australia. As soon as he gets to a point where Cricket Australia is happy, he'll come over," Bobat said.

Bobat was non-committal on where all-rounder Venkatesh Iyer — a high-profile ₹7 crore signing at the auction — can be slotted in the XI.

"We haven't selected a team for our first game yet. Our main objective at the auction was to strengthen the squad. We want competition for places. Adding a player of Venky's quality, experience and calibre is a no-brainer," Bobat said.

RCB changes ownership in a \$1.76 billion deal

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

United Spirits Limited (USL), the Indian arm of London-based Diageo, stated on Tuesday that it had fully divested its stake in Royal Challengers Sports Pvt. Ltd. (RCSPL) to a consortium comprising Aditya Birla Group, The Times of India Group, Bolt Ventures, and New York-based Blackstone's private equity strategy, BXPE, in an all-cash deal worth \$1.76 billion.



According to a regulatory filing made by USL, RCSPL owns and operates the Royal Challengers Ben-

galuru (RCB) franchises in the Indian Premier League (IPL) and Women's Premier League (WPL).

Upon completion of this transaction, the consortium would, through its ownership of RCSPL, acquire the rights to own and operate the IPL and WPL outfits. The RCB teams are the reigning champions in both IPL and WPL.

The women's team won its second trophy early last month while the men's team will begin its title defence this Saturday.

Speculation that RCB would be up for sale has been rife since the stampede outside the M. Chinnaswamy Stadium on June 4, 2025, that killed 11 people during the franchise's title-winning celebrations. Tuesday's announcement concludes the strategic review of RCSPL that was initiated by USL last November.

The transaction is subject to satisfactory completion of customary closing conditions and legal, regulatory and other approvals,

including from the Board of Control for Cricket in India (BCCI) and the Competition Commission of India.

Praveen Someswar, MD & CEO, USL, said: "RCB has grown into the most prominent and commercially successful franchise in the IPL and WPL. It has built a globally recognised brand and a passionate fan base.

"We are excited for the future of RCB under the stewardship of the new owner. As sports enters a new phase of growth in In-

dia and globally, we believe this is in the best interest of the franchise and our stakeholders," Someswar added.

"We are proud to become custodians of RCB and grateful to USL and Diageo for the franchise they have built. RCB's championship-winning culture, its deep connection to Bengaluru, and one of the most passionate fan bases in world sport make this an extraordinary opportunity," stated the acquiring consortium.

Somani-led consortium wins bid to own Royals

Shayan Acharya
MUMBAI

A consortium led by US-based entrepreneur Kal Somani has won the bid to acquire the Rajasthan Royals franchise in the IPL.

The consortium, which was competing against a Birla Group-backed bid and the Times of India group, is understood to have submitted an offer of approximately \$1.63 billion. The change in ownership is expected to come into effect from June.

Somani, who is already an investor in RR, has business interests spanning ed-tech, data privacy, artificial intelligence governance and sports technology. He is the founder of compa-

nies including IntraEdge, Truyo, Truyo.AI and Academician.

The consortium is also backed by Rob Walton of the Walmart family and the Hamp family, which holds majority ownership of the Detroit Lions. Sheila Ford Hamp, who belongs to the Ford family, is also associated with the group.

Meanwhile, the IPL captains' meeting with the BCCI will be held here on Wednesday. Among the points to be discussed are the Impact Player rule, code of conduct, the two bouncers per over rule, checks for the size of bats, replacement of the ball when it is lost or unfit for play, retired out calls, and use of saliva.

Baranica vaults to a new mark

ATHLETICS

Sports Bureau

Tamil Nadu's Baranica Elangovan went past Rosy Meena Paulraj's National record with a mark of 4.22m to win the women's pole vault title on the opening day of the inaugural National Indoor athletics championships at the Kalinga Stadium in Bhubaneswar on Tuesday.

Baranica, who surpassed Rosy's 2022 mark of 4.21m, was delighted with her effort. "It's a good day for me, I entered my name in the record books. I had been trying hard to cross 4.20m but today turned out to be my lucky day," said the 29-year-old, who went for 4.25m but could



Soaring: Baranica came up with a 4.22m effort. BISWARANJAN ROUT

not achieve it.

Local favourite Sarun Payasingh, a footballer-turned athlete, upset Praveen Chithravel to take the men's long jump crown with a personal best of 7.80m, achieved in his second attempt. Chithravel was second with 7.78m, al-

so recorded in his second attempt, following a keen contest with Sarun.

The results (winners only): Men: 800m: Mohammed Afsal (IAF) 1:47.86; **3000m:** Shivaji Parashuram (Rel) 8:09.88; **60m hurdles:** Krishik M. (Kar) 7.71; **long jump:** Sarun Payasingh (Odi) 7.80m; **shot put:** Ravi



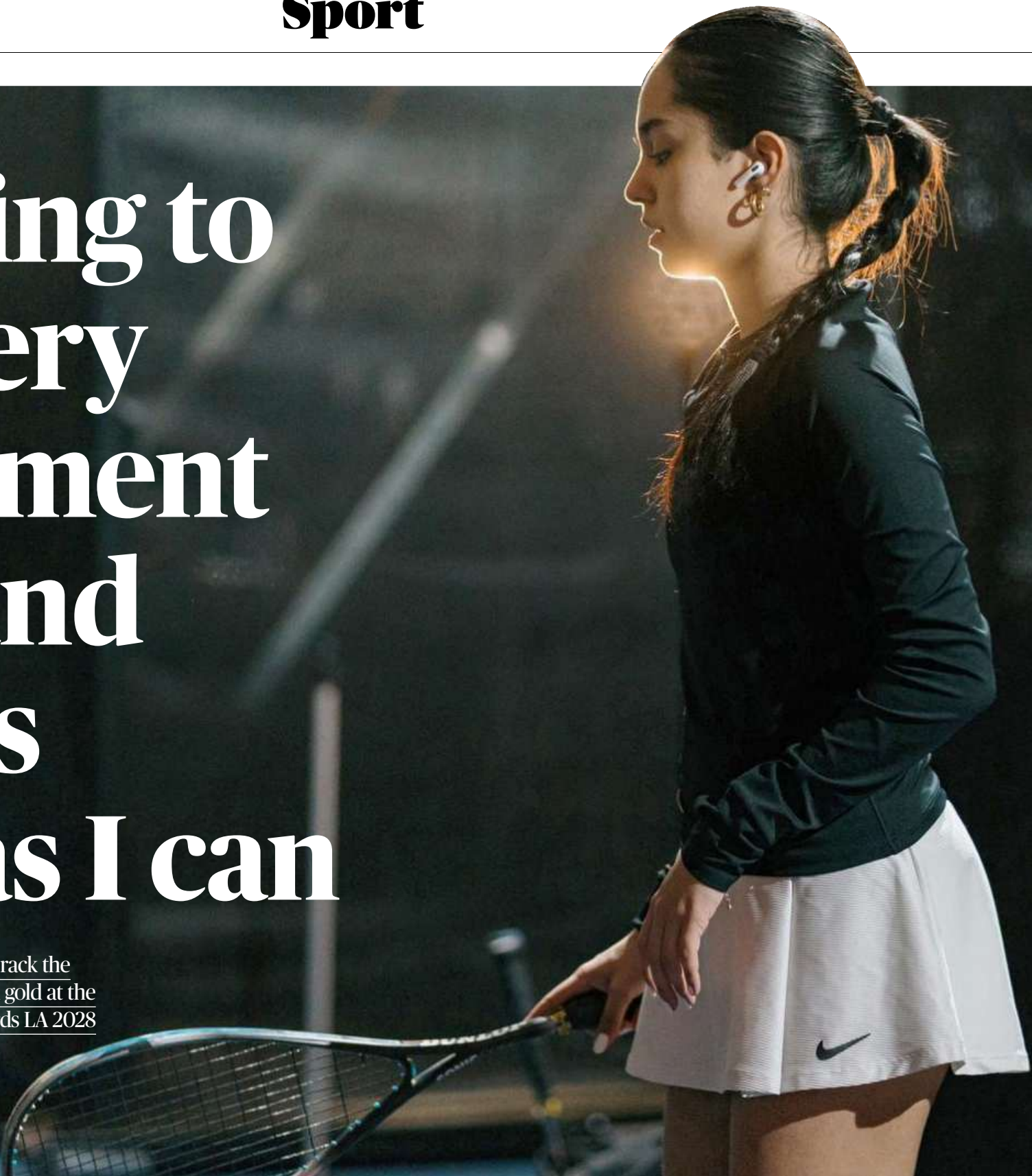
Sarun. BISWARANJAN ROUT

Kumar (BSF) 17.17m. **U-20: 800m:** Lokesh Magendhiran (TN) 1:53.92; **shot put:** Omkar Prasad Nanda (Odi) 17.77m.

Women: 3000m: Priyanka C. (Kar) 9:42.05; **shot put:** Rekha (NCOE, Patiala) 15.63m; **pole vault:** Baranica Elangovan (TN) 4.22m; **long jump:** Anamika K.A. (JSW) 6.05m. **U-20: Shot put:** Dona Maria (Ker) 13.35m.

I'm trying to win every tournament I play and learn as much as I can

The 18-year-old Indian squash star aims to crack the top-10 as early as possible; she hopes to win gold at the Asian Games and take a decisive step towards LA 2028



INTERVIEW

Anahat Singh

K. Keerthivasan

Anahat Singh set the squash stage on fire in Washington last month. Competing at the Squash on Fire Open, the teenager produced a simmering exhibition of skill and composure against some of the world's finest players. By clinching her maiden PSA World Tour Bronze title, Anahat sky-rocketed into the world's top-20, becoming the youngest Asian to achieve the feat in recent times.

What stood out was not only the results but also her approach – especially in the final against Georgina Kennedy. An explosive player with some of the quickest movements on court, Kennedy is a formidable presence on the Tour. Yet, Anahat matched her pace with poise, playing the long rallies with calmness and not rushing to finish points. To defeat the top-seeded 28-year-old from England in straight games (12-10, 11-5, 11-7) was a statement in no uncertain terms.

At 18, Anahat, who clinched the JSW Indian Open women's title in Mumbai last week, is aware that sterner tests lie ahead. Among them is the long road to the 2028 Summer Olympics, where squash will make its debut. She is determined to reach that stage.

In this interview, she speaks about her goals for the World Junior Squash Championships and British Open later this year, not being able to play the senior World Championships, and her burning desire to win the women's singles gold medal at the Asian Games and take a decisive step towards Los Angeles 2028. Excerpts:

This season you did really well, reaching the world's top-20. You became the youngest Asian to do so in recent times by winning your first PSA World Tour bronze title in the Squash On Fire Open. How does it feel?

Yeah, I was, of course, really, really happy going into the tournament. No one really expected me to win. Even now, if I think about it, it's like, I still can't believe it happened. And yeah, it's just something that was unexpected. And I didn't really think about my rankings because I didn't calculate it for the fact that I was going to win the tournament. So I thought that I'd only go a few places up and maybe go to like World Ranking 23 or 24. When I woke up and I saw posts [on social media] saying that I was in the top-20, I was really happy.

What kind of perspective did your first big crown bring to your game?



I think mainly it's about the fact that I know that I can beat the top players. Before, I'd have maybe some close games with them but I'd never be able to convert and win the match. Playing a tournament like this and being able to win three really good back-to-back matches... those were matches that weren't supposed to go my way. Just winning a tournament like that made me believe that it's possible for upsets like this to happen. And that if I'm playing a good game and if I believe in the fact that I can win the tournament, it's definitely possible. I'm trying to win every tournament that I play and trying to learn as much as I can through it, whether it's a win or a loss.

If you look at the previous season (2024-25), you had won nine PSA titles. This season, too, has been good for you as you managed to win your first major PSA World Bronze World Tour title in Washington. Will you opt to play in more bigger events such as Platinum, Gold in the coming months?

I think, yeah, that will be my first step. I've lost in the pre-quarters and a five-setter (to World No. 7 Satomi Watanabe of Japan in the round-of-16 in the Tournament of Champions in

January 2026 and to Tinne Gilis in the Windy City Open in February) in both my last Platinum events. Taking it one step at a time and reaching the quarters and doing better and better. That's the only way out because there's no other way out. Playing the bigger events and getting a chance to reach the later rounds, maybe the quarters, semis.

You have a bunch of elite coaches in the form of India's Saurav Ghosal (former World No. 10), France's Gregory Gaultier (former World No. 1) and Italy's Stephane Galifi (former World No. 5). How much part have they played in improving your skillsets?

I train with Galifi and Gaultier. They both are my main coaches. And then there's Saurav, who's more of my mentor outside the court, where he helps me with what I should do for training and tournaments. If I didn't have the team that I have now, I don't think I would be where I am now. And getting to be with three of them – I don't think I could get a better team than this. They've all been top players in their time. I am getting to be around them and learning so much from them because they understand exactly what it's like to be at this level – all the

challenges, all the ups and downs. Them being my coaches is something that I'm really, really grateful for.

My game has only gone up since I've started working with them and hopefully, I can keep working like that. Having three of them on my side, even if I don't believe I can win, the three of them, no matter who I'm playing against, even if it's a World No. 1 or World No. 2, they really believe that I can win. I also have that certain amount of confidence and belief that I can do really well. And I mean, that's really shown and paid off in the last couple of months.

Apart from the Asian Games which is a major qualifying tournament for the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics, there is the World Championships in Giza, Egypt, from May 8 to 16. What are your thoughts on playing in the Worlds?

I'm not playing that because I have my Std. XII Board exams. I mean, definitely, it is something that I knew I wasn't going to play as soon as my exam schedule came out.

There are so many other events that happen in the year after the Worlds. There's the British Open that's happening from May 30 to June 7. My main aim for this year is to win the

World Juniors, which is happening in Canada from July 20 to 31. As of now, mainly these are the two events in the next couple of months.

Asian Games is the biggest event this year. In the last edition of the Games, you won women's team bronze, and mixed doubles bronze (with Abhay Singh). This time, the singles winner will qualify for the 2028 Olympics...

I'm really, really looking forward to it. The last time that happened, we did really well as a team. And yeah, it was my first time playing and getting two medals was really amazing. But I think this time it's also a qualifying tournament for the Los Angeles Olympics – whoever wins the singles event qualifies automatically for the quadrennial event in 2028. Going into the Asian Games this time is going to be a lot different than any other tournament because if I win this event, I will have an automatic selection for the Olympics, which is everyone's dream. I'm going to push as much as I can and train as hard as I possibly can to try to get gold.

How do you prioritise your tournaments leading up to the Olympics?

I think initially it was a lot harder because I wasn't really getting into all the big tournaments. It was hard to pick and select which ones I'm getting into. Now that my ranking has gone up, I can play every single tournament now. It's a lot easier to pick because you just end up playing in 11 to 15 PSA tournaments in a year. You end up playing all of the big events like the Platinum and Gold events. It's up to you to pick as to where you think you're going to go and do well.

Breaking into the top-20 is done. What is your next objective?

Of course, the next step would be to get into the world's top-10. As you go up in the rankings, it gets harder to climb even one spot up. It's going to be quite hard. But yeah, I think if I do well in the upcoming tournaments, I can speed up my ranking process and climb higher as quickly as possible.

Do you play any other sport to unwind. What are your hobbies?

It's tough to get time between squash and school. Whenever I get time off from both, I like to paint. Even my dad really likes it. He's really good at it as well. I've been doing it since my childhood. It's something that I really enjoy doing as well. My most recent one (painting) was, basically about my identity. I made a mix of squash with pictures of Delhi.

How BioPharma SHAKTI can transform biologics with non-animal models

A class of drugs called biologics is becoming more popular worldwide against many chronic diseases; on the flip side, animal models not do reliably predict their safety and efficacy, prompting scientists to shift to bioengineered, human-relevant systems such as organoids, organ-on-a-chip, and 3D bioprinting

Mohit Nikalje
HYDERABAD

In 2006, London woke up to a tragedy. Six healthy men involved in a phase I clinical trial of theralizumab, a monoclonal antibody (mAb) designed to treat rheumatoid arthritis, developed multiple organ failure. The antibody triggered an intense immune reaction that the researchers did not observe in rhesus monkeys in preclinical tests because their immune cells responded differently from human immune cells.

The Northwick Park Tragedy, as it was called, became a textbook example of why animals cannot be used as proxies to test human drugs. Similarly, in 2022, the mAb semorinemab failed to work in 457 patients with Alzheimer’s disease during phase II trials despite demonstrating effectiveness in a preclinical mouse model.

These mAbs, vaccines, and insulin all belong to a growing class of drugs called biologics – large, complex molecules produced by living cells. Their use is rising worldwide as they treat many chronic diseases.

Recognising their importance, the 2026 Union Budget of India announced the Biopharma SHAKTI strategy to boost domestic production of biologics and their generic counterparts, biosimilars.

However, animal models may not reliably predict the safety and efficacy of biologics. This has prompted a shift towards bioengineered, human-relevant systems such as organoids, organ-on-a-chip, and 3D bioprinting, which are derived from human cells and thus replicate human biology more faithfully.

Human-relevant models

These models are collected under the term non-animal methodologies (NAMs) and are used worldwide to reduce the use of experiments in animals. For example, last year, the U.K. published a roadmap to phase out animal experiments and promote the adoption of NAMs.

Thanks to the New Drugs and Clinical Trials (Amendment) Rules 2023, India is also promoting the use of NAMs in the development of novel drugs. However, their potential remains untapped in the domain of biologics and biosimilars.

“Biologics are highly specific,” University of Illinois adjunct professor Sarfaraz Niazi said. “They bind to particular receptors in the human body. But those receptors are sometimes missing or function differently in animals, which makes animal testing less predictive.”

One 2024 study in *Cell* reported a breast cancer-on-chip model to study the effectiveness of CAR T-cell therapy, a leading biologic therapy, against solid tumours.

While CAR T-cell therapy has proven effective against blood cancers, solid tumours like breast cancers pose additional challenges like abnormal blood vessel formation and difficulties for T-cells



Even if non-animal methodologies are promising models, they are not as accessible as animal systems. GETTY IMAGES

to find and attack the cancerous cells.

The breast cancer-on-chip model recreated this tumour environment in the lab, and the authors of the 2024 study perfused T-cells through it to observe whether they could enter the tumour and mount an immune attack, assessing both treatment benefit and potential safety risks without animals.

These models can also reduce costs and shorten development timelines, making them attractive to pharmaceutical companies. A 2019 analysis in *Drug Discovery Today* estimated that organ-on-chip technologies could lower overall drug development costs by 10-26%. They also found the time required for lead optimisation, when scientists identify a promising drug candidate from a pool of molecules, could drop by 19%.

Future of biologics

Even if NAMs are promising models, they are not as accessible as animal systems. More than 90 academic labs in India are working on these models. However, the innovation here is not translating into industry use. “Translating NAMs into industry-ready assays requires a clear context of use, robust documentation, and standardised, reproducible protocols, even before qualification. While institutions support entrepreneurship, sustained commercialisation needs stronger, modern policy support,” Kasturi Mahadik, Chief Manager at the Centre for Predictive Human Model Systems (CPHMS), AIC-CCMB, said. (Note: the author works at CPHMS.)

The development of NAMs also

Biopharma SHAKTI also supports biosimilars – generic versions of biologics reverse-engineered once the original product goes off patent. However, regulatory adjustments are involved here, which require greater attention from the government

requires sustained funding and infrastructure. With an outlay of ₹10,000 crore, Biopharma SHAKTI can provide the necessary backing.

“I think the best use of these funds would be not to develop a single product but to build systems that enable many companies to do so,” Dr. Niazi added.

“The culture of entrepreneurship is also a challenge in India,” Narendra Chirmule, CEO of SymphonyTech Biologics, said. “Although there is an increase in the number of start-ups and MSMEs in biologics (supported by DBT, ICMR, and other grants), exponentially greater investment, as well as support for the development of supply chain materials, is needed to create real impact. Additionally, investors are not well versed in the risks and potentials of the biologics industry”.

Regulatory, market challenges

Another area supported by Biopharma SHAKTI is biosimilars, generic versions of biologics that are reverse-engineered once the original product goes off patent. However, there are additional financial risks and regulatory adjustments

involved, which require greater attention from the government. One challenge is patent evergreening, which allows the exclusive rights of an original biologic to be extended. For example, although the intravenous form of the cancer drug trastuzumab was approved in 2000, the manufacturer later introduced a subcutaneous formulation with a separate patent. Because of this prolonged market exclusivity, cheaper biosimilar versions were not available until 2018.

Before being commercialised, biosimilars also have to receive a nod from the Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation (CDSCO), India’s apex regulatory body. These approvals are based on set guidelines; however, the updated guidelines are still in draft form.

“While India has been updating its biosimilars guidelines to accommodate NAMs, implementation has been slow, and regulatory confidence in independently validated NAM models is still evolving. If accelerated, this would expedite the adoption of NAMs in the biologics and biosimilars field, helping Biopharma SHAKTI achieve its goals,” says Dr. Mahadik.

Therefore, aligning with industry realities and securing regulatory clarity for their use will make biosimilars and biologics manufacturing in India faster, more predictive, and cost-efficient, thus realising the vision set by Biopharma SHAKTI.

(Mohit Nikalje is a science communicator at the Centre for Predictive Human Model Systems, Hyderabad. mohitnikalje1234@gmail.com)

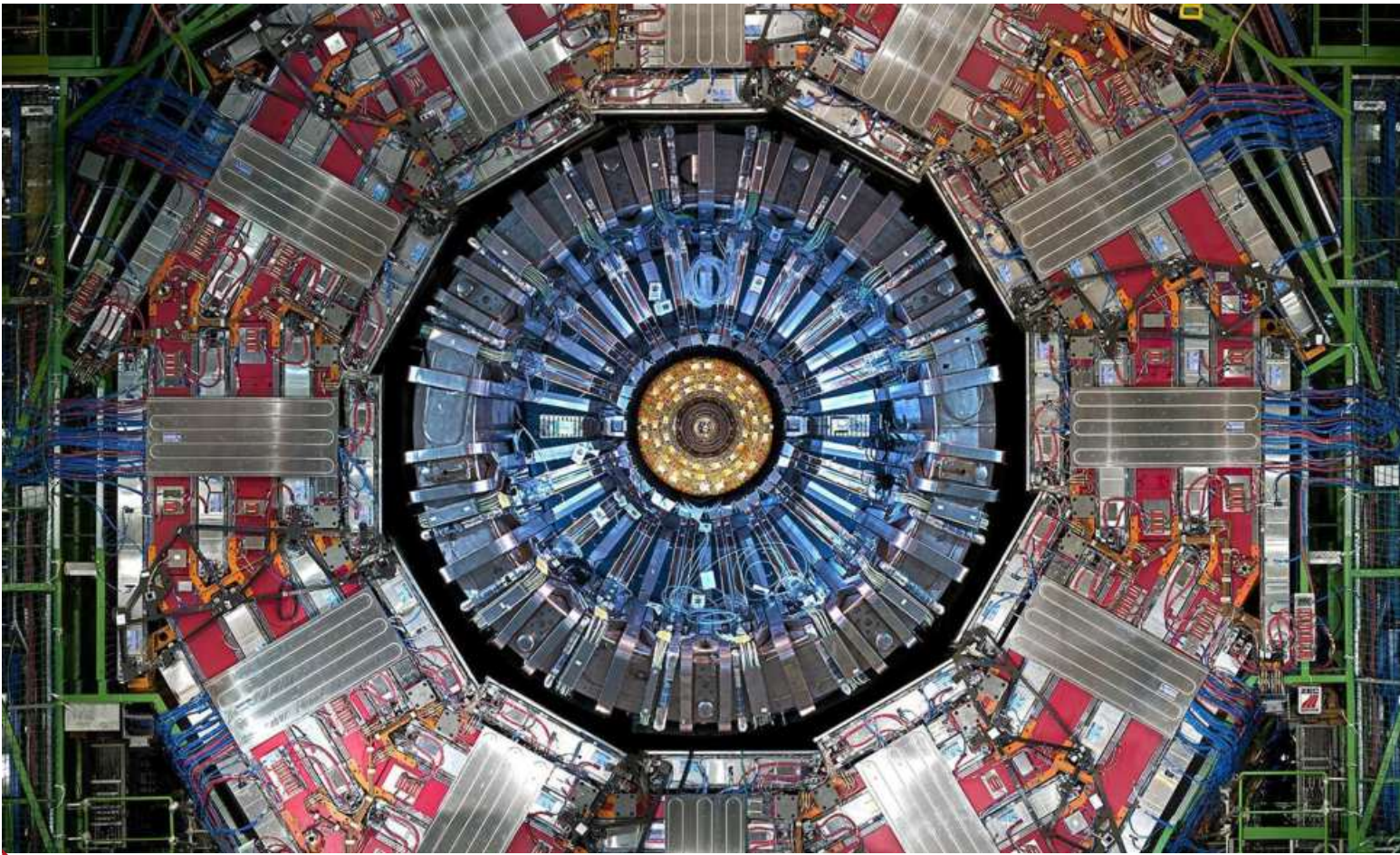
THE GIST

Monoclonal antibodies, vaccines, and insulin all belong to the growing class of biologics – large, complex molecules produced by living cells

Recognising their importance, the 2026 Union Budget of India announced the Biopharma SHAKTI strategy to boost domestic production of biologics and their generic counterparts, biosimilars

Thanks to the New Drugs and Clinical Trials (Amendment) Rules 2023, India is also promoting the use of non-animal methodologies in the development of novel drugs. However, their potential remains untapped in the domain of biologics and biosimilars

BIG SHOT



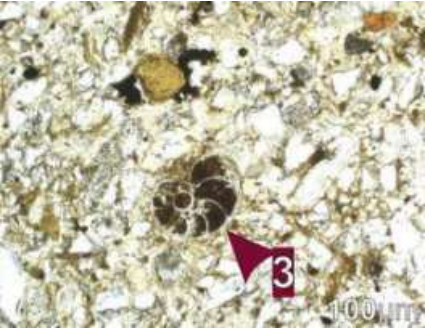
Quantum discovery: A side-on view of the world’s largest superconducting solenoid magnet at the CMS detector on the Large Hadron Collider, near Geneva. The Collider has discovered a new particle, its 80th so far, that has been named ‘Xi-cc-plus’. Scientists hope the particle, which is similar to a proton but four times heavier, will reveal more about the strange behaviour of quantum mechanics. CERN

WHAT IS IT?

Dwarka Basin: an ancient haven

In February, researchers from IIT-Bombay, the Indian Statistical Institute, and IISER-Kolkata reported that fossil beds in the Dwarka Basin date back to the early Miocene epoch. They identified 42 species of snails, including four new to science, that indicated the area was once warm and rich in nutrients. The findings are expected to help scientists better understand the ancient marine environments and biodiversity of western India.

The Dwarka Basin is a significant geological and archaeological region located off the coast of Gujarat. It mainly refers to a sedimentary basin in the Kathiawar Peninsula that contains layers of marine rocks and fossils. Geologists are interested in the Basin to understand the earth’s history over millions of years. The Basin features rock layers such as the Gaj and Dwarka formations dating back to the Miocene epoch (23 million to 5.3 million years ago). These layers hold a wealth of marine fossils, including ancient snails and foraminifera. Energy companies are also exploring the basin for potential signs of oil and gas deposits beneath the volcanic rock. The area’s popularity surged in the 1980s when marine archaeologists



Petrographic thin-section image of an Ammonia sp. microfossil in the Gaj formation of the Dwarka Basin. DOI: 10.1017/JPA.2025.10198

found submerged pillars and over 120 stone anchors on the seafloor near the modern city of Dwarka. Experts from the Archaeological Survey of India continue to dive into the basin to map these structures. The Gujarat government has also announced plans to launch submarine tourism here to allow visitors to see the structures firsthand.

For feedback and suggestions for ‘Science’, please write to science@thehindu.co.in with the subject ‘Daily page’

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Funds allocated in the Delhi Budget for underground wiring

200 in ₹ crore. The Delhi Budget 2026-27 allocated ₹3,942 crore to the UT's power department, including ₹3,500 crore for subsidy payments and ₹200 crore for shifting overhead wires underground. The government doubled the funds for shifting overhead high-tension and low-tension wires from ₹100 crore in 2025-26 to ₹200 crore. PTI

Projects cleared under border development scheme since 2004-05

39,248 More than 39,000 projects have been approved under the Border Area Development Programme, which is in its 'sunset phase', since FY 2004-05 in the bordering States and Union Territories, including Uttar Pradesh, Rajasthan and Jammu and Kashmir, Lok Sabha was informed on Tuesday. PTI

People arrested in Iran over online activity 'undermining security'

466 Iranian police arrested 466 people over alleged online activities undermining national security, state media reported on Tuesday, in one of the largest sweeps since the war with Israel and the U.S. began. Overall arrests this month have crossed 1,000, with those detained accused of filming sensitive sites or "cooperating with the enemy." REUTERS

Number of drones fired at Ukraine by Russia overnight

400 Russia launched nearly 400 long-range drones at Ukrainian civilian areas overnight, Ukraine's air force said. Russia also fired 23 cruise missiles and seven ballistic missiles at Ukraine, hitting at least 10 locations, according to the air force. Ukrainian civilians have endured relentless barrages since Russia's full-scale invasion over four years ago. AP

Number of civilians killed in Sudan in drone strikes this year

500 Over 500 civilians were killed in drone strikes in Sudan between January and March 15, 2026, the UN said on Tuesday. A sharp spike in the use of drones in Sudan underlines the devastating impact of high-tech weapons in populated areas, said Marta Hurtado, spokeswoman for the UN rights office. AFP

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When the Chief Justice steps away

The recusal of CJI Surya Kant from the Chief Election Commissioner appointment law challenge case raises important questions about conflict of interest, the doctrine of necessity, and the limits of pre-emptive judicial direction, as well as the need for a statute governing judicial recusal

LETTER AND SPIRIT

V. Venkatesan

In March 20, Chief Justice of India Surya Kant stepped away from hearing a batch of petitions challenging the Chief Election Commissioner and Other Election Commissioners (Appointment, Conditions of Service and Term of Office) Act, 2023. The legislation replaced the Chief Justice of India with a Union Minister, on the selection panel for appointing the Chief Election Commissioner and other Election Commissioners, superseding the Supreme Court's 2023 interim arrangement. "I will be accused of conflict of interest," the CJI remarked before directing that the case be listed on April 7 before a bench comprising judges not in the line of succession to the office of the Chief Justice. While the order directs the Registry to list the case before a Bench to be earmarked separately by the Chief Justice of India, his oral remarks while hearing the case, *Dr. Jaya Thakur v. Union of India* (2024), raises questions that will linger long after the Bench is constituted. CJI Surya Kant is the second CJI to recuse from hearing the case. Earlier, CJI Sanjiv Khanna recused from hearing the same case in 2024.

The doctrine and its foundations
Recusal flows from one of the oldest maxims of natural justice: *nemo iudex in causa sua* – no one shall be a judge in their own cause. In its modern form, the Supreme Court has moved from strict automatic disqualification for pecuniary interest, as in *Manak Lal v. Dr. Prem Chand* (1957), toward a standard of real likelihood of bias. *Ranjit Thakur v. Union of India* (1987) refined this further, holding that a reasonable apprehension of bias, and not merely a remote possibility, justifies withdrawal.

Every court to have addressed the question has held that the decision to recuse, rests on the judge's own conscience. No party can compel it, and no statute in India codifies the standard, unlike in the United States where Section 455 of Title 28 of the United States Code requires a federal judge to disqualify themselves in any proceeding in which their impartiality might reasonably be questioned.

The NJAC precedent

The most directly relevant Indian precedent cuts the other way. When the validity of the National Judicial Appointments Commission Act, 2014 was before a five-judge Constitution Bench in *Supreme Court Advocates-on-Record Association v. Union of India* (2015), recusal was sought against Justice J.S. Khehar on the ground that he would eventually become Chief Justice and therefore had an institutional stake in whether the Collegium or the NJAC governed future appointments. Justice Khehar refused. His reasoning rested on two pillars. First, the conflict infected every judge on the bench, since all would eventually be part of the Collegium if the petitioners succeeded, or subject to the NJAC if they failed. Second, and more fundamentally, he invoked what legal systems call the doctrine of necessity: when the only available forum is also the forum that faces a disqualifying conflict, the conflict must yield to institutional obligation. "If I were to accede to the prayer for my recusal, I would be initiating a wrong practice, and laying



Judicial discretion: No party can compel recusal, and no statute in India codifies when a judge must step aside. GETTY IMAGES

down a wrong precedent," he held.

In his concurring opinion, Justice Kurian Joseph added that a judge choosing to recuse bears a constitutional duty of transparency, that indicating reasons for withdrawal is itself part of the oath of office taken under the Third Schedule of the Constitution.

The present case

The structural logic of NJAC applies equally to the CEC law challenge, and arguably with less force for recusal. Every sitting judge of the Supreme Court is a potential future Chief Justice under the seniority convention established by the Second Judges case. The conflict of interest that moved Chief Justice Surya Kant to step aside, therefore, afflicts every member of the court simultaneously. The doctrine of necessity then compels the conclusion that the Supreme Court must hear the case regardless, since no alternative court of equivalent jurisdiction exists, while acknowledging the conflict openly, as the NJAC Bench did. The CJI's recusal, viewed through this lens, represents a departure from a principle the court itself laid down a decade ago.

A direction that binds successors

More troubling than the recusal itself is the accompanying oral direction (as reported by the media, though the order uploaded is silent on this). By specifying that the replacement bench must exclude judges in line to become Chief Justice, the CJI has made a prospective determination

about the disqualification obligations of judges who have not yet considered the question for themselves. Recusal is an act of individual judicial conscience. It cannot be mandated in advance by a predecessor. To pre-assign a conflict of interest to judges who have not adjudicated whether one exists is to collapse the distinction between institutional incapacity and personal disqualification.

There is a further problem the direction does not account for: the office of the Chief Justice has occasionally passed to judges outside the expected seniority line due to the resignation, health, or death of those ahead of them. A judge constituted on the replacement bench as someone outside the line of succession could, through such contingency, subsequently reach the office of Chief Justice. The prophylactic rule, designed to eliminate the appearance of self-interest, cannot account for the accidents of judicial mortality.

CJI Surya Kant's decision suggests another incongruity. If the CJI's recusal of himself and the other judges, who are in line to become CJI in the future is justified, can he, as Master of the Roster, decide which of the other judges can hear this case, given that the order authorises him to earmark the bench? In the recent debate on the no-confidence motion against Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla, many members from the Opposition queried whether he could choose the

person who would preside over the House during the proceedings, even while choosing to recuse himself. The answer from the government, that the Speaker's post does not envisage a vacancy in office, may be accurate, but it still fails to satisfy the doubts on conflict of interest, which led to the decision to recuse in the first place.

The need for codification

India has no statute governing judicial recusal, no binding code of conduct enforceable against Supreme Court judges, and no mechanism to review a recusal decision once made. The American experience illustrates both the value of clear rules and their limits without an external review mechanism: Section 455 provides a codified objective standard, but at the apex level it remains entirely self-enforced.

The CEC law dispute, in which two successive Chief Justices have now recused from the same case, underscores the urgency. When the question of who appoints the guardians of elections is left to a bench constituted by informal direction rather than principled rule, the deficit is institutional as much as it is individual.

India's constitutional framework is well-served by judges who exercise their discretion with care. It would be better served still by a framework that transforms that discretion into obligation. (V. Venkatesan is a senior legal journalist and researcher.)

THE GIST

On March 20, Chief Justice of India Surya Kant stepped away from hearing a batch of petitions challenging the Chief Election Commissioner appointment law, citing 'conflict of interest'.

The accompanying oral direction on constituting a replacement bench excluding judges in line to become Chief Justice, amounts to a prospective determination by the CJI on disqualification obligations of judges.

The conflict of interest that led CJI Surya Kant to step aside, can be said to affect every member of the court. However, the doctrine of necessity compels the Supreme Court to hear the case, since no alternative court of equivalent jurisdiction exists.

